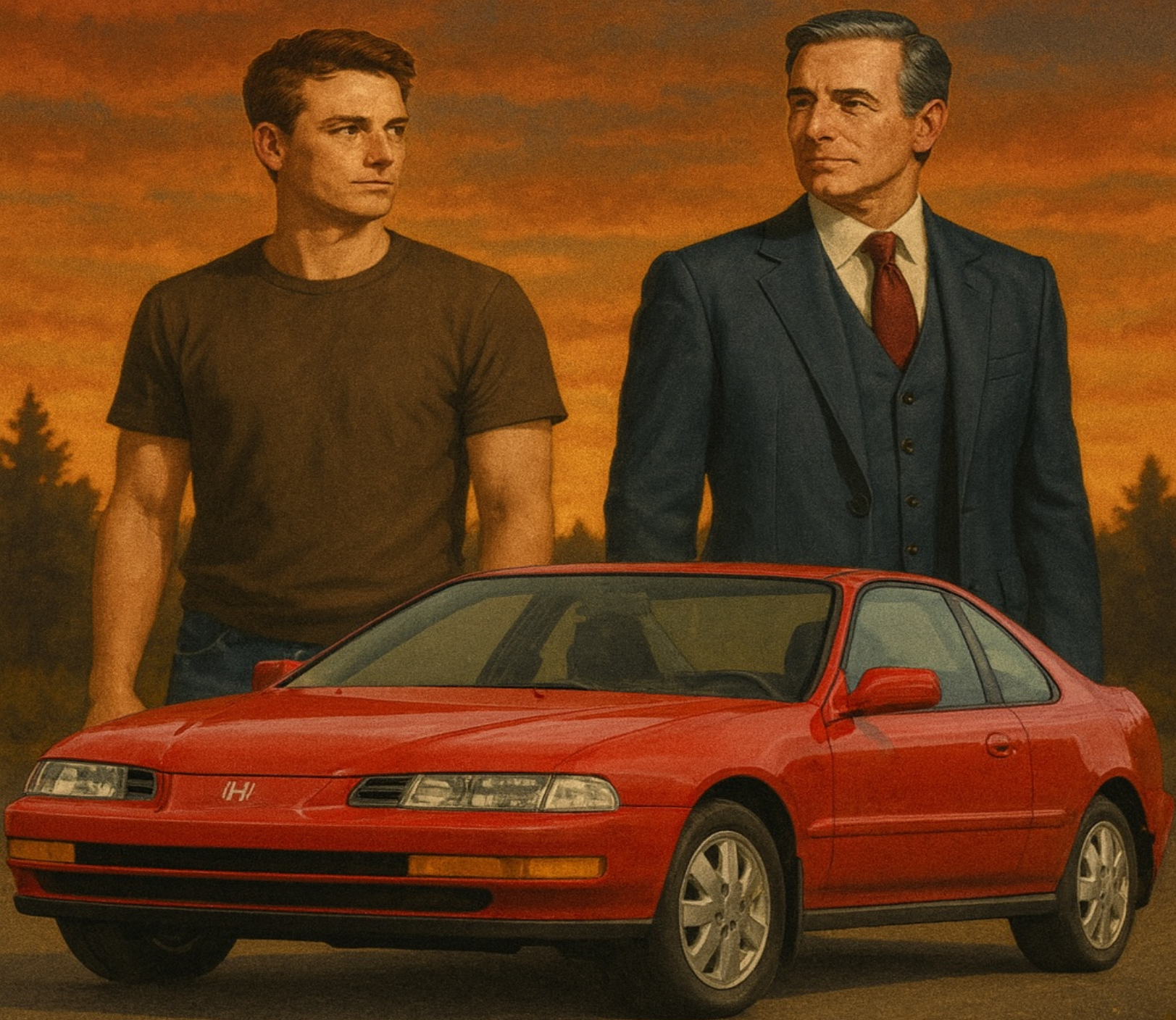


THE HITCHHIKER

T.T. RIDER



The Hitchhiker

A novel by T.T. Rider

Copyrighted Material

The Hitchhiker Copyright © 2025 by Vladimir
Yangurskiy

Under the pen name T.T. Rider

All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced, stored, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without prior written permission of the author.

ISBN (TBD)

First Edition

The Hitchhiker is a work of fiction.

All names, characters, places, and events exist only within the imagination of the author.

While certain settings or historical details may resemble real locations or moments in time, they are used purely to lend authenticity to the story.

No person, living or deceased, is portrayed intentionally, and any resemblance is entirely coincidental.

This book is meant as a reflection on universal human experience, not a depiction of real lives.

*"Fly by night, away from here
Change my life again."
Neil Peart, "Fly by Night" (1975)*

Chapter 1: The Meeting

8:15 PM. Near Boise, ID

One more hectic week wrapped up, one more win to his name. Steve should have felt pleased about it, but somehow, such victories no longer brought him any true joy. “Well,” he mused, “success is still success.” The company would benefit, and so would he.

Even so, the dull hollowness lingered after an exhausting week in Boise, Idaho. At least he could look forward to a peaceful eight-hour drive back home to Seattle.

Steve enjoyed covering long distances behind the wheel. There was a time when he’d driven all the way across the United States, from one coast to the other. Trips out to San Francisco, Salt Lake City, Las Vegas, and Los Angeles had become such regular events for him that he’d stopped keeping track of how often they happened.

These days, his packed schedule didn’t really give him the chance to spend days on the highway, but Boise was close enough that he couldn’t deny himself this small, asphalt-scented pleasure.

The roads went quiet after dark; patrols grew lax. Just Steve, the open road, and his thirty-year-old, well-kept Honda Prelude. Its outdated dashboard, analog dials glowing a soft green, always calmed him.

Steve had only recently swapped his equally ancient Mazda RX-7 for the Honda on Facebook Marketplace, then dedicated several weekends to restoring it to something like its original condition. There was a faint rattle he still hadn’t fixed, but otherwise,

the car performed flawlessly on the way down here, and Steve felt sure it would carry him home just as smoothly.

There was no rush; no one expected him back, and no one would be glad if he arrived early. So he planned to make the most of the drive home, roll into Seattle around five in the morning on Saturday. He'd sleep until he felt like waking up, maybe order Chinese from his favorite little takeout spot, and binge-watch another TV series. Sunday would probably be spent tinkering with the car again, looking for that rattle, just trying to keep himself occupied.

And then Monday would roll around. He'd head back to doing what, at least on paper, made him happiest: his job.

But for now, he had his drive ahead of him.

* * *

8:25 PM - 8:50PM. Near Boise, ID

Steve always looked forward to this season in the Pacific Northwest, when daylight lingered until nearly ten at night. Even now, though it was past eight, the sun still clung stubbornly to the horizon, washing the land in a warm crimson glow. The distant gold hills looked scorched by the fading light, and the air still shimmered from the day's heat. Fields of brittle grass swayed gently, whispering beneath the steady hum of the highway.

Lost in his own thoughts, Steve's attention was suddenly caught by something odd ahead.

A man was striding along the edge of the highway. The road stretched endlessly ahead, pale concrete glowing faintly in the dusk. Heat ripples wavered above the asphalt, and power lines stood in solemn rows, their shadows stretching thin across the slope.

The man moved among them as if on a casual evening stroll: steady, unhurried, and entirely out of place. His dark suit was spotless, despite the dusty road; his tie was perfectly straight; and in his right hand, he carried a briefcase as if it were the most ordinary thing in the world.

That alone was strange enough. It's risky to walk so close to an interstate at dusk, but what truly caught Steve off guard was the man's composure. Utterly calm, indifferent to the passing cars and the encroaching night.

The sight was odd enough that Steve acted on instinct. He pulled his car over onto the shoulder, stepped out, and waited for the intriguing stranger to draw nearer. He wasn't sure why he had stopped: curiosity, boredom, or something stranger.

Moments passed, the last of the sunlight slipping away. As the man approached, Steve got a clearer view.

The stranger appeared to be about fifty to fifty-five years old, dressed in a bespoke three-piece suit tailored to fit his tall, athletic frame perfectly. His crisp white shirt and deep burgundy tie, adorned with a tie clip sparkling with a large gemstone, looked entirely out of place here in rural Idaho. Polished leather dress shoes and a gold watch completed his ensemble.

He would have blended into Manhattan with ease or looked quite at home in a corporate boardroom. The supple leather briefcase

he carried only emphasized his air of sophistication.

But out here? In farmland, Idaho? Steve's curiosity was overwhelming. If he hadn't stopped, he would have obsessed over this encounter for hours.

As the man drew close, Steve took a few steps forward and called out,

"Hi, can I help you with anything? You seem a bit out of place here."

The stranger approached with a genial smile. "Do I?" he paused briefly before continuing without waiting for Steve's answer.

"Yes, I believe I find myself in something of a bind. Quite foolish of me, really. I left my car at a deserted rest stop unattended while I tended to some rather prosaic business. When I returned, barely minutes later, the car had vanished. Along with it went my mobile phone, which I'd left charging."

"That's awful!" Steve exclaimed. "Would you like me to call the police?"

"That would not resolve my immediate dilemma," said the man with a sigh. "No doubt my dear old Cadillac is already being taken apart in some dubious garage or perhaps has been abandoned somewhere unsavoury. Regrettable as it is, it's merely a vehicle. What truly matters is getting back on track toward my destination as soon as possible."

Steve pointed towards his red Honda. "I can give you a ride wherever you want along my way to Seattle."

"Thank you kindly, good sir," replied the man in refined tones. "Regrettably, my journey takes me toward Los Angeles, but I would

very much appreciate your generous offer until we reach somewhere I might arrange alternate transportation.”

He extended his hand cordially. “Permit me to introduce myself. My name is John.”

Steve shook John’s hand and was surprised by his firm grip. “I’m Steve,” he replied.

“Much obliged, Steve,” John responded before heading for the passenger door.

Only then did Steve notice the Coronado Leather Briefcase was chained to John’s wrist with a polished steel link.

When Steve returned behind the wheel, John had already settled into the seat and buckled up, his briefcase resting on his lap.

Steve started the engine but hesitated as another thought occurred to him.

“John, if you’d like, I could take you back to Boise Airport, it’s not too far out of my way, and we’d be there in less than an hour.”

John regarded him with renewed interest. “You would travel completely out of your way, adding at least ninety minutes to your journey, for someone you’ve just met?”

Steve simply shrugged. “Why not? It’s not like anyone’s impatiently waiting for me in Seattle.” His words sounded more bitter than he intended as he turned northward toward his original route.

John smiled gently. “I understand completely. I suppose I’m something of a lone wolf myself.” After a slight pause, he added, “Unfortunately, the airport won’t be much help to me. Rather embarrassing to admit, but flying frightens me terribly.”

Before Steve could respond, John continued smoothly, "And renting a car isn't possible either. I left my wallet and my phone behind when my vehicle disappeared. Without identification, no agency will rent one out to me, even though I do still have some cash on hand."

Steve nodded sympathetically, "Yeah. That is rough."

John gave him another warm smile. "Indeed, it is." Then he fixed Steve with an appraising look. "Tell me, how would you feel about having a little adventure?"

Steve blinked in surprise. "Adventure? What do you mean?"

Without hesitation, John explained further: "Suppose I asked you for a slight change in plan. Drive me all the way down to Los Angeles?"

Steve laughed outright at that notion: "Slight detour? That's an understatement! You're asking me to turn around and go south for fourteen hours, then head back home again for another sixteen or so! Sorry, I just don't have time for such a detour from my route."

John didn't seem fazed at all by this reaction and went on calmly.

"I promise it'll be worth your while. Naturally, I'll cover all expenses: fuel, food, accommodation, and beyond that, I'll pay you one thousand dollars immediately and another upon arrival in Los Angeles if we get there on time."

The sheer absurdity made Steve laugh again; here was this total stranger offering him two thousand dollars just to drive all night and day across half the country.

His first instinct was obviously to say 'no'. It was ridiculous!

But somewhere at the back of his mind, other thoughts began forming: No one cared whether he arrived today or tomorrow. Not like Alexa, his only regular conversation partner, would notice.. Also, he hadn't driven down to Los Angeles since... well, since happier times.

Maybe he could leave his Prelude with an old colleague and just catch a flight back home after catching up. But was it wise to hit the road with someone he barely knew?

Almost reading Steve's mind, John assured him earnestly:

"Let me reassure you, nothing illegal is involved here at all. There's no hiding from police, no drugs or weapons smuggling. You won't be breaking any laws whatsoever."

Steve grinned and asked, "Well, I just met you. How do I know your intentions aren't to harm me in every way, like the rape, dismemberment, or killing, in any order?"

John responded with a smile, "I hate to disappoint you, but you're not my type. And as for dismemberment, can you imagine the blood and gore you'd have to endure? It's an unsanitary process. So, no, I have no plans to kill you or engage in any sexual activity with you, voluntary or involuntary. Sorry to disappoint."

"That's quite all right," Steve laughed.

He sat quietly for a bit, wrestling with his thoughts, then turned to John. "Alright. I'm in. I'll take you to LA."

"Marvellous," John declared, his tone brightening. With deliberate grace, he pressed his left index finger to the biometric lock on his bag and neatly opened one of its compartments.

Steve fought the urge to sneak a glance inside, instead fixing his eyes firmly on the road ahead. Meanwhile, John reached into the bag without so much as a downward glance and retrieved a tidy bundle of cash: hundreds, fifties, twenties, even fives, rolled together.

"Here you are," he said, handing it over, "precisely one thousand dollars."

Initially, Steve was meant to refuse. He wasn't doing this for money, but then he changed his mind. Without bothering to count the cash, Steve slid the bills into the side pocket of his cargo shorts. He quickly punched the new destination into his phone, mounted on the windshield to his left.

"LA, here we come," he said with a grin. "Fourteen hours or so."

Chapter 2: The Crossing

9:20PM near Marsing, ID

As they set off heading south, Steve checked over the directions with a sense of satisfaction. From their spot in Idaho, he figured the smartest way to reach LA would be to skip the Interstates and stick to state and county roads instead. It was a route he had never used before, and he was genuinely looking forward to winding through the mountains of eastern Oregon. He made a mental note about where the gas stations were, less frequent than he'd have liked, but manageable nonetheless. Pressing down on the accelerator, he relished the familiar growl of the trusty VTEC under the bonnet and the way his almost-classic Japanese sports car handled each turn effortlessly.

The only thing that unsettled him was how impossible it seemed to have an actual conversation with John. John remained courteous, but his replies were brief, sometimes just a few syllables.

"So," Steve ventured, trying to start a conversation, "where were you coming from?"

"From the east," John answered, not offering anything further.

As they headed south, Steve reviewed the route with quiet satisfaction. From their spot in Idaho, he figured the better way to reach Los Angeles was to skip the Interstates and take the state and county roads instead. He'd never taken this route before and looked forward to winding through the mountains of eastern Oregon. He noted where the gas stations fell, less frequent than he'd like, but manageable enough. Pressing the accelerator, he relished the growl

of the VTEC under the hood and the way his nearly classic Honda Prelude hugged each curve.

What unsettled him most was the silence; conversation with John felt impossible. The man was courteous enough, but his answers came short and measured, just a few syllables before the hum of the tires reclaimed the space between them.

“So,” Steve ventured, searching for anything to break the quiet, “where were you coming from?”

“From the east,” John said, nothing more.

“Nice,” Steve said, forcing a polite tone. “How long had you been traveling before you ran into trouble today?”

“For quite some time,” John replied.

Steve glanced at the road ahead, trying to think of another angle.

Steve fell silent. After a moment, he said, “The Pacific Northwest is stunning this time of year. Anywhere from April to November, it’s easily the best place to live in the States.”

John kept his eyes on the road. “Yes. It is rather agreeable.”

Steve took another shot at getting more out of him. “How does it compare to where you’re from?”

Again, John gave nothing away. “It’s much the same.”

Steve waited for more, but none came. The silence thickened between the hum of the tires.

They drove wordlessly for a while until Steve decided to try another approach. “John, are you into sports at all? Football? Hockey? Soccer? Maybe racing, like Formula 1?”

John glanced politely at Steve and replied in his refined accent, "I confess I do not follow many team sports," he said in that refined accent of his, but Formula 1 is quite dear to my heart."

At last, Steve thought, something they could talk about! "What do you make of this year's championship? Seems like McLaren's lads might actually clinch it, at least one of them."

John answered with composed confidence, "McLaren has presented remarkable form this season and will probably secure the constructors' title. Nevertheless, my wager remains on the Red Bull virtuoso. As McLaren's drivers divide the points between themselves, Red Bull is bound to capitalise on their advantage, and I suspect the reigning champion shall retain his crown."

"Personally, I don't think it'll play out that way, but hey, we'll see soon enough!"

"Indeed."

"So," Steve asked, "how long have you been following F1?"

"Well," John replied with a subtle smile, "for about as many years as your car has been roaming roads like these. Perhaps a few more besides."

"No kidding! Which era stands out as your favourite?"

John offered a rare grin. "The days when refuelling was still permitted." Glancing at the dashboard, he added delicately, "Are you quite certain we have sufficient fuel? Ought we stop somewhere just to be safe?"

Steve waved it off. "No worries, we're nearly in Oregon now. There should be a petrol station just after we cross the border, according to my map. We'll be there soon."

“If you say so. You are in command behind the wheel,” John said with dignified politeness. Then he added gently, “Might I request that you observe the speed limit? The sheriffs here are fond of stopping out-of-state motorists; it’s almost a pastime. They insist offenders appear in court even for the smallest infractions, often sentencing them to community service. Imagine returning here every week just to work off your sentence.”

Steve shrugged but eased up on the accelerator enough to bring them down to the posted speed. He grimaced inwardly, it wouldn’t be nearly as enjoyable driving all the way to California stuck at the limit.

* * *

9:30PM - 9:45PM near Marsing, ID

They drove in silence until John raised a hand toward the cruiser parked on the shoulder. “Ah, there he is. The solitary Sheriff, waiting to ensnare some hapless offender,” he said with a trace of amusement.

Steve glanced at the speedometer and noticed he was a bit below the posted limit. He grinned as they rolled past the patrol car. To his astonishment, though, the cruiser suddenly came to life, its red and blue lights erupting like fireworks in their mirrors.

“What the hell!” Steve blurted out, easing off the gas and steering his Honda over to the shoulder.

John regarded him with mild curiosity. "Why are you so agitated? You've done nothing wrong, have you? Surely you haven't run afoul of any regulations. Remain calm, please. This is merely a customary inspection."

But Steve couldn't get his nerves under control. Dealing with cops always made him jittery, even when he'd done nothing wrong; it was some old reflex he couldn't shake. It didn't make sense, yet he couldn't help it.

And now he was stuck with this strange hitchhiker who might be dangerous for all he knew.

Expecting what would come next, Steve pulled out his license, registration, and insurance, ready to hand them over.

The police cruiser pulled in behind the Honda, and after a short pause, the Sheriff stepped out and strolled toward the passenger side of the car.

As they waited, John unclipped his briefcase, produced a polished lapel pin, and fixed it to his jacket with practiced precision.

Steve stared: what kind of civilian carried something like that?

He rolled down his window, and as soon as the Sheriff stopped at the passenger side, John spoke up first.

"Good afternoon, Officer Devon," he said, glancing at the name tag with a faint, patronizing smile. "Would you be so kind as to explain the reason for this stop, aside from breaking the tedium of your shift?"

To Steve, John's way of talking came off as way too pushy and cocky. The Sheriff obviously picked up on it, too. He swept his heavy flashlight beam across the empty back seat, then shone it right in

John's face and barked, "License, registration, and proof of insurance!"

John didn't even flinch, just added, "Please," and kept staring straight at the Sheriff, acting like the light was no big deal.

They had a silent standoff for a second or two until the Sheriff snapped, "Now!"

John just held out his hand toward Steve, snatched the paperwork, and handed it over to the Sheriff. "Here you are. Please."

The Sheriff checked everything under his flashlight, then shot a look at John. "Are you carrying any weapons or illegal drugs?"

John replied coolly, "Negative."

The Sheriff pressed on. "Where are you headed?"

John answered right away, "Classified." The Sheriff's face went red even in the harsh glare of the flashlight, so John quickly added, "All I'm allowed to say is that we're crossing through Oregon and on our way to Nevada. And we need to do it without attracting attention."

The Sheriff looked like he'd had enough. He pointed at John's briefcase and snapped, "What's in the bag?" Then, noticing the chain connecting it to John, added, "And what's with the chain? Why are you handcuffed to it?"

John answered flatly, not even trying to smile, "Obviously, it's for security. No one can take it from me. As for what's inside, I'm afraid you'd need a court order to see it. My superiors would be extremely disappointed if I let you look inside. So, no."

The Sheriff looked like he was about to lose it, and Steve was sure they were both about to get hauled out of the car, but then John

switched gears.

“Officer Devon, apologies if I’ve come across as difficult. Please understand that both my partner and I are under a great deal of pressure because of this assignment. We absolutely have to reach our destination quietly, or some crucial evidence could end up destroyed. Of course, it’s your right to stop or even detain us, but doing that would ruin months of work.”

The Sheriff gave John a long look, weighing things up. “You guys Feds or something?”

John finally cracked a smile. “Let’s just say our superiors are based in Washington.”

The Sheriff hesitated, half tempted to make their lives hell, half afraid to get tangled up in whatever this was.

In the end, he clearly decided it wasn’t worth the trouble. He handed the paperwork back to John and grumbled, “Alright. Get out of here.”

John smiled in return, “Thank you, Officer Devon. Before we go, may I ask just one thing?”

“Shoot.”

“What was your reasoning for pulling us over? Pure curiosity, professional courtesy.”

“You were driving under the speed limit. Out here, only folks who are drunk or high do that. Everyone local usually goes about ten over.”

John nodded, smiling again. “Appreciate it, Officer Devon. That’s good to know.”

He rolled up the window, turned to Steve, and waved for him to start driving.

"I told you, driving faster is better," Steve remarked.

John replied dreamily, "Perhaps you are right. But only in this occurrence."

* * *

9:45PM near Marsing, ID

"Did you really have to be that rude and condescending to him?" Steve asked angrily. "You acted like he was beneath you. That was disgusting! He had the right to stop us, check our papers, and, as you pointed out, we didn't do anything illegal. So why go out of your way to make him angry? What was the point of all that attitude?"

Rude, was I?" John asked mildly. "I thought I was simply exercising my right to ask for the reason behind the stop."

"Yeah, but you could've done it more nicely, like you did at the end. And what was all that about a 'secret mission' and us being partners? I'm not your partner, John. I'm your driver. That's it."

"It was merely a turn of phrase," John waved Steve off, "In some regions, such as Texas, it's customary to call someone 'partner' in situations like this."

"Really? Never heard anyone do that."

"That's your problem, not mine."

“Whatever. Then what was that nonsense about secret missions and superiors in Washington?”

“Are you confident it was nonsense? How do you know it wasn’t true?”

The question caught Steve off guard. He realized he had no real idea who his passenger was, or what this trip was really about. The thought left him uneasy, though his anger began to fade.

John used the silence to press on. “Tell me something, Steve. Why did you act guilty the moment that cruiser lit up behind us? Your whole mood changed; you looked terrified. Yet you hadn’t done a thing wrong, had you?”

Steve hesitated.

“Had you?” John pressed.

“No,” Steve admitted.

“But you sure didn’t seem innocent,” John went on. “You shrank back and got all nervous. Is that how you always respond to authority figures?”

Trying to defend himself, Steve said, “Honestly, I was worried about you. You told me to keep a low profile, even had me stay under the speed limit, which actually made us stand out more,” Steve couldn’t help taking a jab at John. “And let’s face it, I don’t really know who you are! For all I know, you could be a fugitive, a terrorist, or something. I don’t want to end up arrested and shipped off to Guantanamo just because of you.”

John laughed heartily. “Rest assured, I am nothing of the sort! And as far as I’m aware, your government doesn’t send its own citizens off to Guantanamo.”

“Not yet,” Steve shot back.

“Steve, I’d wager you’re a very different man at work. I pride myself on judging character well, and you strike me as someone who would speak up for what he believes is right, regardless of someone’s rank or authority. Am I mistaken? How many times have you gotten into trouble for that? And how often were you right?”

Steve grinned ruefully. “Too many times, and it cost me plenty when I was starting.”

“Then why change when it’s government officials? Why lose your nerve?”

Steve fell quiet, thinking. He’d never really asked himself that before.

“I guess it goes back to my early years here,” he said at last. “I moved to the U.S. when I was barely twenty, alone, with lousy English. I dealt with rude immigration officers in New York, sleazy lawyers who took my money, and this constant fear that one mistake would ruin everything. The agents there lost my file more than once. I waited over five years for my Green Card. All that time, I lived with the dread that one clerk could toss my papers and send me back to Bosnia.”

His voice softened. “So yeah, it left a mark. Even now, I get overly polite, almost submissive, around officials. I ask instead of demand, even when I’m right, because I know how easily one missing document can mess up your life.”

After a long pause, John asked gently, “Do you plan on carrying on like this forever?”

Steve chuckled. "Nope. I'm working hard at changing this pattern. Making steady progress, too. Sure, I'll always try to be polite, but I'm done acting like a pushover, or at least most of the time."

"Splendid," John replied approvingly, then switched topics abruptly. "By the way, how are we doing on petrol?"

"Oh, we've got somewhere between a quarter and half a tank left. The gauge isn't all that precise on this car. Don't worry, though, we should hit a gas station in about ten minutes once we cross into beautiful Oregon."

Chapter 3: The Gamble

10:15PM - 10:25PM near Jordan Valley, OR

As the red Honda Prelude rolled into the gas station, Steve grinned, "Alright, let me fill her up real quick. While I'm doing that, do you want to hit the restroom? I know I need it, but after what happened earlier, I don't want to risk leaving the car empty, even at a lonely spot like this."

John responded in his usual measured tone, "I am perfectly fine, thank you."

"Suit yourself," Steve shrugged, popped the lever, and stepped out into the cool night air.

He unscrewed the fuel cap, slipped the nozzle into place, and reached for the pump controls. That's when he noticed that they were off.

Steve checked each of the other three pumps and found they were all switched off as well. The gas station had closed for the night and wouldn't reopen until 6 AM. With little real hope, more out of stubbornness than hope, Steve walked over to the shopfront, only to find it locked up and dark inside. Only the hum of a distant transformer broke the silence.

A quick check confirmed there were no restrooms available either.

His most pressing problem was urgent but easy enough to handle. He ducked behind the bushes to take care of business, then returned to face the real problem: no fuel.

Pondering this dilemma, Steve returned to the car, replaced the nozzle in defeat, and slid back into his seat.

John regarded him with an unspoken query.

Steve didn't leave him hanging long. "The station's shut. Looks like they close at ten and reopen at six," he said, glancing at his dashboard clock. It read 10:11 PM. He sighed, "If it weren't for that cop back there, we would've made it!"

John said evenly, "By my reckoning, we could have stopped at least seven times in Idaho alone."

Steve grew annoyed. "Yeah, we could've! But I picked this one. It should've been open! They got rid of that silly law about needing an attendant and most places are fully automated now. So why shut everything down overnight?"

His voice rose almost to a shout.

John remained composed as ever. "Perhaps by regulation, there must still be an attendant present during operation, and out here, it is improbable they'll see customers at this hour."

Steve considered that reasoning and admitted, "You're probably right. That was dumb of me." He pulled out his phone to search for nearby stations and gave a frustrated chuckle.

"Unbelievable! It actually lists the hours right here on Google Maps! Should've checked before."

John didn't say anything further, and Steve appreciated that silence; it left him feeling sheepish and childlike, a sensation he hadn't experienced in decades.

The darkness beyond the windshield felt thicker now, pressing close against the glass.

After a few more minutes scrolling through options on his phone, Steve declared, "We're short on options," he muttered. "Everything around here's shut after dark. There's one open across the border in Nevada, maybe reachable if I nurse the tank. Or we head back to Idaho and fill up there," he turned to John, "Honestly, though, I think going back is the safer bet."

John shook his head, slow and sure. "I fear that is not a wise course of action. Should we encounter that same sheriff again whilst retracing our route through his jurisdiction, well, explaining ourselves would become rather complicated. No, our only sensible choice is to continue onward."

"I get it," Steve agreed quietly. "Let's press ahead." He patted the dashboard fondly. "C'mon, Baby Honō, don't fail us now."

A glimmer sparked in John's eyes as he glanced at Steve. "Honō?"

"Yeah, 'Honō,' Steve said proudly. "Japanese for flame. Fits her."

He added with mock seriousness, "So be nice to her, alright? Treat her right and she'll look after you too."

John gave an amused smirk but kept silent.

Steve started the engine. The Honda's headlights swept across the deserted forecourt before settling on the dark ribbon of highway ahead, one hundred miles of mountain road and a quarter tank to carry them through.

* * *

11:55PM - 12:00AM near McDermitt, NV

The next hour simmered with tension. Normally, Steve would have loved this road, the switchbacks, the pull of gravity, the rare thrill of four-wheel steering holding the car to the asphalt. But now he'd gone full conservation mode, keeping revs low and gliding downhill whenever possible, doing everything he could to coax a few more miles from the tank. He stared almost hypnotically at the fuel gauge, silently begging Baby Honō to hold on. If he'd been alone, he might've whispered those prayers aloud, but not with John sitting beside him.

John remained silent, and for once, Steve was grateful. To stay alert, he broke his own rule about sugar, nursing a can of Red Bull, then trading it for jerky, then a bottle of Coke.

It was a trick Steve had learned years ago. You couldn't nod off if you were chewing or sipping something. Singing worked too, though he wasn't about to test that theory with John listening.

When Steve offered him a drink, John declined and, with his usual precision, unlatched the briefcase just enough to slip a hand inside. He withdrew a small bottle of FIJI Water, its label catching the dashboard glow.

Steve wondered what else he kept in that stupendously expensive briefcase, but it was pointless to ask. The soft hum of tires and the faint slosh of water from John's bottle filled the silence.

At last, they neared the Nevada border. The station should've been only a few miles away. Straightening with relief, Steve guided the Prelude off the highway toward salvation.

The side road was empty, the asphalt cracked and forgotten. Even if they ran out of gas here, Steve told himself, a short walk wouldn't kill them.

Then the station came into view, or what was left of it.

The building was a hollow shell, its windows smashed, pumps stripped to rusting skeletons. A battered price board leaned at an angle, riddled with bullet holes. The only sign of life was the wind rattling a loose panel.

Steve's stomach dropped. Luck wasn't just bad tonight; it was vindictive. The next working station lay forty miles away, and he doubted Baby Honō could manage four.

The anxiety that had been tightening in his chest for an hour finally snapped. He wanted to yell, laugh, punch something, anything.

"Why the hell does Google list this place as open?!" he shouted, voice breaking with frustration.

John, as ever, looked untroubled. He pointed toward a warped cardboard sign propped by the fence. Scrawled across it in thick black marker: **Fuel →**

"Well," John said calmly, "I daresay we're already quite thoroughly muddled. What are your thoughts on following yon sign and trusting our fortunes to fate?"

Steve let out a shaky laugh. "You got that right, we're totally screwed. But what choice do we have? That sign's probably older than this dump."

He lifted his phone, **No Service**. Not even enough to make a call. The words on the screen punched harder than any

disappointment. His fists clenched, knuckles white, until John's voice cut through.

"Steve, I suggest you decide quickly," John said evenly. "Languishing here idly merely wastes what little fuel remains. Shall we try that road?"

Steve exhaled hard. "Yeah," he said. "Let's give it a shot."

* * *

12:15AM - 12:45AM near McDermitt, NV

At midnight, the full moon flooded the desert road with a cold, silvery light, turning the world into a scene from a low-budget horror flick. They passed a sand quarry on the right, a few dilapidated buildings on the left, windows gaping and dark. The land felt deserted, airless, as if life itself had moved on.

Still, Steve clung to a rule he'd drilled into his team countless times: *If everyone agrees to a plan, you don't change it on a whim. Only new evidence earns a new decision.*

And right now, there was none. Nothing to make him question the choice to push deeper into Nevada, farther from the highway and any sign of civilization.

Eventually, a faint light appeared ahead. And right at that moment, Prelude coughed, shuddered, and ran out of fuel at last.

Steve cut the headlights to save the battery, pulled the handbrake, and climbed out.

The moonlight greeted him with an icy breeze. The stillness felt absolute. “Feels like we just landed on some planet with no tech and no life at all,” he muttered.

But that faint glimmer still shone ahead, some hint of hope.

Leaning through the window, Steve said, “We’ll have to push her about half a mile. Road looks straight, and the moon’s bright. You up for it?”

John said nothing. He rolled down his window, climbed out, shut the door, and placed his hands on the fender. “Ready.”

Twenty minutes later, they reached it, a squat building crouched beside the road, its tin roof dull in the moonlight. Strips of blue-and-silver fringe fluttered in the cold wind. Above the awning, a faded sign read:

Patrick’s Quick Stop • Gas • Ice • Groceries • Corndogs • Milk.

The brickwork was cracked and peeling; the place looked untouched for decades. Two weather-beaten picnic tables leaned near a pump so ancient it belonged in a museum. A pair of ice chests glowed under a weak bulb whose greenish halo barely spelled *ICE*.

Yet through the grimy glass door, a neon sign still buzzed **OPEN**, a stubborn patch of life refusing to die.

“Well,” Steve murmured, “this is either rescue or the next act of a B-movie.”

John just nodded toward the door. “Go on. I’ll stay with the car, just in case.”

Steve stepped inside. A bell tinkled overhead, startling a handful of late-night shoppers, five men, two women, waiting in line

with groceries. For a second, everyone froze, the stranger and the locals sizing each other up under the tired fluorescent lights.

Behind the counter stood an elderly man straight out of a sixties postcard, white beard, friendly eyes, grin wide enough to bridge decades.

“Well, hello there, young fella!” he called in a warm country drawl. “Can’t say I expected company at this hour. What brings you out tonight?”

“Gas,” Steve said. “That pump outside, still working?”

“Gas?” The man chuckled. “What made you think we were even open?”

“Sign out there pointed this way,” Steve replied. “I’m out completely.”

Patrick slapped the counter, laughing. “Ha! Forgot about that old sign. Hardly anyone ever comes down that stretch. Folks round here either live in town or claim they’re workin’ the quarry.” He winked. “But yeah, sonny, the pump still runs. Want me to fill her up?”

Relief flooded through Steve. “Please.”

Patrick waved to the customers. “Let me ring these folks up, then we’ll get you fixed with some gas. Name’s Patrick, same as the sign.”

Minutes later, everyone drifted outside. The old pump squealed and rattled as it fed life back into Baby Honō. A tall man with wild hair and sharp gray eyes nodded toward John, who sat motionless in the passenger seat.

“Who’s that? Some kinda Fed? We don’t want feds around here.”

Steve smiled easily, voice light. “Nah, that’s my uncle visiting from Europe. Wants to see the *real* America, not just cities.”

“He don’t talk much,” the man growled.

“Doesn’t speak English,” Steve replied. “Only Finnish.”

The man squinted. “Say something in Finnish, then.”

“Hyvää päivänjatkoa,” Steve said cheerfully. “Means ‘have a good day.’”

The big man barked a laugh and clapped Steve’s shoulder. “Good enough.” He wandered off down the road, and the rest followed.

The night turned colder. Patrick disappeared back inside, leaving Steve alone beside the car. He changed into jeans quickly in the dark, tucked the cash John had given him into his jacket, then shut the trunk.

With both tanks topped off, Honda and Red Bull alike, he waved to Patrick through the window, slid behind the wheel, and turned the car toward the highway.

The old neon sign flickered behind him, a tired green heartbeat fading into the desert night.

* * *

12:50AM *near McDermitt, NV*

After that improbable rescue, Steve's spirits soared. Nevada's desert shimmered under the full moon, and Baby Honō's VTEC hummed like it was singing thanks for being set free.

Without warning, John, who had been silent and still since they left Patrick's oasis, turned to him.

"Tell me, why are you so anxious? Why this obvious fear? Running out of petrol could be inconvenient, but it's not the end of the world. Yet you acted like everything was about to collapse."

"I just don't want to get stranded out here," Steve said. "I promised I'd get you to L.A., and I nearly blew it."

"Then your fear was less about danger," John mused, "and more about losing control over your own affairs?"

Steve thought for a moment. "Both, I guess. No gas, no cell service, no idea who lives around these parts. That guy at the store? If he came across us stranded on the roadside, he could've robbed us and buried us in some sand pit. Nobody would ever know." Steve smiled, "Funny thing, though, while it was happening, I wasn't afraid. Only afterward did my brain start replaying disasters. During it, all I cared about was getting fuel."

"So you spent an hour gripping the wheel in guilt and frustration rather than fear itself?"

"Pretty much."

"Yet when we saw that light ahead, your mood shifted, even though you had no idea what it meant for us. Why?"

"Hope," Steve said simply. "Even a tiny chance that things might work out makes me believe they already have. When the engine finally stopped, I wasn't nervous anymore. I saw the light,

and I believed it meant help. I switched to a problem-solving mode and executed a plan."

"Fascinating," John murmured approvingly, then switched topics, "Your improvisation about me being Finnish rather tickled me."

"Didn't want anyone hassling you," Steve grinned. "You start sounding too high-and-mighty, someone would've taken offense. And that sand quarry was not that far away."

"You appear to have quite an erroneous view of me. Frankly, your comment borders on discourtesy." John replied, faint irritation in his tone, before softening. "But no matter. It stands to reason with our brief acquaintance, you might form such opinions. Tell me, do you actually speak Finnish? I hear it's quite the labyrinth."

Steve laughed. "Not really. My ex in Sarajevo was Finnish; she taught me that phrase. Didn't want to risk Bosnian: too many people remember the war, but not which side Bosnia was on. Arabic spooks folks these days. Romanian sounds too much like Spanish, and I'd get cornered trying to fake it. So Finnish it was. Worked perfectly."

"Indeed, it did," John said quietly, turning his gaze back to the empty, moonlit highway ahead.

Chapter 4: The Diner

1:30AM - 2:30AM near Winnemucca, NV

After another forty-five minutes on the road, Steve's stomach reminded him that jerky and Red Bull weren't dinner. It growled loud enough to make him laugh.

He stretched his arms and legs. "Man, I could really go for some midnight breakfast right now. You hungry too, John?"

Honestly, if John had reached into his briefcase and pulled out a sandwich, heck, even a hot one, Steve wouldn't have blinked.

But John merely regarded him and said, "Indulge yourself as you wish. I remain entirely content," then motioned toward an approaching exit sign listing fuel stops and diners.

Among the fast-food chains, one name caught Steve's eye: **Timeless Diner**, promising, "No need to rush, the time stops here."

Steve threw a glance at John. "How about that place?"

"I leave it to your discretion," John replied in his usual measured tone. "I am not particular. Feel free to sample the local fare if that is your desire."

"Perfect," Steve said brightly. "Exit's in five miles. Hang a left, and it should be right off the highway."

Ten minutes later, he eased the red Honda to a stop outside the **Timeless Diner**, the kind of roadside relic you could still stumble across anywhere in America if you wound the clock back seventy years.

The neon sign flickered weakly, its blue script still clinging to mid-century elegance despite decades of weather. The building itself

was a slim aluminium capsule with a softly arched roof, once orange, now streaked with rust. Chrome strips dulled to pewter ran along the sides, and long windows, half-blinded and peeling, revealed a dim interior. A plain white rectangle above the door marked where a menu board must have hung long ago.

Behind it loomed a larger wooden structure, the two buildings leaning together like old friends holding each other up.

Steve's excitement couldn't be dampened. "Shall we?" he said, already climbing out.

Inside felt like a time warp had stopped in 1957: a snug corridor of red-leather booths, opposite a gleaming Formica counter, with round chrome stools fixed to a black-and-white floor. The air carried the faint ghosts of fried oil, coffee, and something sweetly nostalgic.

Every surface was alive with colour and clutter: stickers, badges, postcards, and faded Route 66 signs layered across the walls and ceiling. A low hum from the refrigerator mixed with the buzz of the neon outside, like static in a dream.

At the far end of the counter, a waitress turned as the bell above the door chimed.

She looked barely twenty-something, dressed in a pastel-blue uniform edged with pink-and-white plaid. The dress fit neatly, a silver name tag glinting when she moved. Blonde curls framed her face, and a touch of shimmery lipstick completed the retro look.

She radiated that blend of warmth and wary curiosity only diner veterans manage, someone who's seen every sort pass through but still greets each new face with a spark of interest.

“Mornin’, y’all, welcome to the Timeless Diner,” she said with an easy grin. “I’m Janis; I’ll be takin’ care of ya this fine mornin’. Sit wherever suits ya. Plenty of elbow room tonight.” She gestured toward the empty booths for emphasis.

Her voice was chipper but practiced, the kind that had been worn smooth by repetition. Still, beneath the friendliness, Steve thought he caught a faint trace of weary irony.

He chose a stool halfway down the counter, waving for John to join him. John sat beside him and set his chained briefcase carefully on the counter.

If Janis found that odd, she didn’t show it. She slid menus toward them with practiced grace.

Steve skimmed quickly. “Two eggs sunny-side up with potatoes and steak, plus toast and coffee.”

Janis gave an apologetic smile. “Sorry, hon, we’re fresh outta steak. But we got bacon, ham, or meatloaf.”

“Any meat’ll do,” Steve said.

“You got it!” She turned to John. “And what can I get for you, sir?”

“I shall have two soft-boiled eggs with toast, please. And may I request a bottle of water?”

“If you’re wantin’ sparkling,” Janis said, “I don’t think we got any left.”

“Still water will do nicely.”

“No problem at all.” Janis nodded briskly. “I’ll get that goin’ for y’all.”

She flipped on an ancient coffee maker that coughed like a smoker, measured grounds from an unmarked bag, and disappeared through a swinging door. "Grandpa! Wake up now! We got customers!"

A muffled reply drifted back.

"Come on, Grandpa, travellers need breakfast," she coaxed.

Moments later, an elderly man appeared, easily past eighty, shuffling straight to the cooktop. Without a word, he read the order slip and began to work.

Janis fetched a cold bottle of water and a glass for John, then a mug and silverware for Steve. Everything about her movements spoke of routine. The coffee maker hissed and grumbled in rhythm with Grandpa's muttering at the stove.

Janis poured Steve's cup, flashed him a grin, and called over her shoulder, "Y'all's food'll be up in just a few minutes!" Then, leaning on the counter, she asked, "So, where y'all headin'?"

John looked as if conversation were a chore, so Steve answered. "L.A."

Her eyes brightened. "Well, ain't that somethin'! I ain't never been out that way myself. Y'all from there?"

"Seattle," Steve said. "We're just passing through."

She laughed softly. "Seattle, huh? Shoot, must be real nice seein' new places all the time."

She drifted back to her perch at the counter's end, humming along with the jukebox that wasn't playing.

While they waited, Steve's gaze wandered across the diner's chaotic collage of postcards and stickers, and, occasionally, to Janis

herself. She was lovely in that effortless, country-girl way, the kind that didn't need to try. He wasn't the type to chase women half his age, but he couldn't help smiling whenever the glint of her hair caught the neon's tired light.

* * *

1:30AM - 2:30AM near Winnemucca, NV

To say the food was dreadful was an understatement. It was simply abysmal. Steve's eggs were alright, maybe fried a little too hard for his liking, but they were edible. The potatoes were a random assortment of undercooked and burnt, but the meatloaf was completely inedible. The gravy had a strange sourness, yet Steve could still taste gritty grains of sugar. The meat was like leather, and after one attempt, Steve gave up trying to cut it. He ate his eggs and polished off the toast, which, surprisingly, was perfectly fine.

John's plate wasn't any more appetizing; his supposed soft-boiled eggs were cooked solid right through. John, however, showed no sign of displeasure. He just ate them as they were presented and then moved on to his toast.

Janis gave them a few minutes to eat before she moseyed over with the bill. She set it on the counter between them. Running around the kitchen had made her hot, so she unbuttoned the collar of her uniform and loosened a few buttons to get some air. "How was everything for ya?" she asked, putting on a professional smile. Steve was about to offer a polite, neutral response, but Janis leaned

over the counter and whispered, "Ah, you don't gotta tell me. I know it probably wasn't good." She leaned in a little more, and the top of her uniform sagged, giving Steve an unexpected glimpse of her 'goods'. Janis quickly adjusted her outfit back to decency, smiling with a flicker of embarrassment. "I'm sorry. This place's goin' downhill fast. Our last cook left three weeks ago, so Grandpa, the fella who owns the joint, had to come outta retirement and get back on the grill. Ain't easy for him, you know, bein' almost ninety."

Steve offered a polite smile back. "The eggs were OK."

Janis let out a melodic, girlish laugh. "Yeah, that's about the only thing he can still get right these days." Her tone turned sad. "Yep. This place is dying. The locals stopped comin' in a long time ago, and we don't get that many travelers passing through anymore. I figure we're gonna have to shut the doors for good any day now."

Steve replied, "That's a shame. I like the vibe in here." He gestured around the room. "You could try to turn it around. Maybe let your grandfather actually retire, find a new cook, stick some ads up on the highway, talk to the folks around here."

Janis chuckled sadly. "Oh, he ain't my granddaddy. That's just what we all call him 'round here. I've just been rentin' a room in his house out back and helpin' out at the diner since I was in high school. So this place ain't mine, and it never will be. And truth is, I sure don't wanna end up like Grandpa, stuck workin' in the same diner since he was my age."

John glanced at the check and took a few notes from his pocket. Steve offered, "I'll get the tip."

John nodded, then got to his feet and turned to Janis. "Pardon me, miss. Would it be possible to use your washroom?"

Janis looked back at him with a hint of embarrassment. "Well, we have one, but it's on the fritz." She glanced toward the back of the diner, then back to John. "I don't suppose Grandpa'd mind if you just walk straight through the back into the main house. The bathroom's the second door on your left." She then added reassuringly, a sparkle in her eyes, "It's alright. For one thing, you don't look the type to go robbin' the place, and for another, there ain't nothin' to steal in there anyway." She waved for him to follow. "Here, let me show you the way."

John gave a slight nod and followed Janis.

She came right back out, grabbed their dirty plates, and took them to the sink in the back.

She stayed there for a minute before coming back and hopping onto the stool next to Steve.

He turned to face her and noticed that something about her seemed different. He couldn't quite put his finger on it, but she had a softer, more womanly air about her now.

Janis asked, "So, where y'all comin' from? Seattle?"

Steve smiled. "It's a long story." He then added, "By the way, I'm Steve, and my partner here is John."

He saw her expression flicker for just a second, so he quickly clarified with a smile, "Business partner, I should say."

Janis smiled back. "That's fine by me. I'm a live-and-let-live kinda girl. I don't care who folks are datin', so long as they're happy."

Steve smiled. "My thoughts exactly. But I'm telling you the truth. John and I have some business in L.A., so that's where we're heading. Then I'll drive back up to Seattle, which is where I live. You see, I love driving, so putting a couple thousand miles on the clock is no big deal for me."

Janis commented sadly, "As I said, I ain't never been to L.A. Fact is, I'm twenty-one and I ain't never been much of anywhere, except for one trip to a gymnastics competition in Las Vegas with my school. But I was only eleven then and didn't see a whole lot." She paused, her sadness deepening. "Everyone I grew up with has already left this shithole, and when this place finally shuts its doors, I don't know what I'm gonna do."

Steve thought for a moment before saying, "What's keeping you here? Parents? Grandpa? Why don't you leave, too? You could go to L.A., San Francisco, or even Vegas. They're always looking for people in the hospitality industry. I'm sure you could find a good, decent job there."

Janis smiled faintly. "Yeah, I've thought about it, but it's just plain scary, headin' out into the world all by my lonesome. Maybe that's why I've held on to this place for so long. But you're right. It's time to move on."

Steve smiled at her. "Great! You've made the first step, you've set your mind to it!"

Janis smiled back, waited a beat, and then, as if the idea had just occurred to her, she asked, "Would you take me with you to L.A.? I just need ten minutes to grab my stuff and I'll be ready!"

The question caught Steve off guard. He'd just been making conversation, giving her the same kind of pep talk he'd give his own daughter if she were asking for advice. He shook his head. "I'm sorry, but I can't. First off, my car's too small. It's got back seats, sure, but they're not fit for anyone bigger than a toddler, especially for a drive that long. Also, John and I still have some business to talk over. I'm sorry, but I just can't," he repeated.

Janis's expression changed, becoming playful. She murmured, "I don't take up much room. I can curl up in the back, no problem. And I promise, I'll be a good girl! Unless," she looked directly into Steve's eyes, her voice dropping to a silky, suggestive murmur, "unless you want me to be a bad girl."

Janis hiked the hem of her uniform up, exposing more and more of her leg until it was apparent she wasn't wearing a thing underneath. She took Steve's hand and pressed it against her bare skin, then, in a swift, practiced motion, undid the remaining buttons of her dress and leaned toward him, giving him an eyeful of her impressive womanly treasures, just as bare. She pressed them to Steve and whispered in his ear, "And I'm very good at being a bad girl." She leaned back a bit, continuing in a normal voice, "I ain't askin' you to take me home forever. I'm just asking for a ride to any big city. I don't have money to pay, and I don't expect a free ride. So, if you can do this for me, I'm ready to do somethin' for you in return."

It was both completely unexpected and somehow predictable at the same time. The devil on his shoulder was whispering, *Take the deal. It's not like you're forcing her. She's a beautiful girl, and it's been a*

long damn time. There's no harm in enjoying yourself a little. But the other voice, the voice of reason, pushed back. You don't need this kind of trouble right now. Enough crap has happened on this trip already, and bringing another person into the mix would be a mistake. Besides, she's young enough to be your daughter! Don't be one of those creepy old guys! But the devil was insistent. She's sexy. Hot. Ready and willing. You deserve to have some of that worry-free fun you used to have! Take her!

But the voice of reason was stronger. You can always find someone who isn't wholly dependent on you. If you take her with you, you'd be taking advantage of her situation, and you've never, ever been that man.

Steve pulled his hand back. The voices in his head continued their argument. He looked at Janis and said, "Janis, you're an amazing girl. And yes, I really hope you escape this, as you call it, shithole, and sooner rather than later. But don't sell yourself short. I get that you're ready to use every asset you've got, including that beautiful, young, sexy body of yours, but I just feel like it would be wrong of me to take you up on that."

Steve pulled out the stack of assorted bills John had given him, which felt like ages ago back in Idaho, placed them on the counter, found a hundred-dollar bill, and pushed it toward Janis. "Let me tell you what I would do in your place. Or, actually, what I did when I came to this country around your age, but unlike you, I didn't speak much English. I took a Greyhound to Chicago and started with any job I could find, learning how life worked there. And eventually, I figured it out and made a decent living. So," he placed the bill in her hand, "I like you, and I want to help you. Take this money, pack your bags, and get on the next Greyhound out of here. I'm sure you

have some savings that will help you start a new life.” Steve was pretty sure she did, judging by her recent-model iPhone. You don’t buy one of those with your last dollar. Then again, maybe you do. In any case, it wasn’t his business.

Janis held her gaze on the stack of bills on the counter, then looked back into his eyes and held Steve’s hand. “Thank you! You’re a good man. And yes, I will leave this place as soon as I can.”

But then something in her voice, in her body language, her entire demeanor, shifted. With her long, elegant fingers, Janis reached out and very slowly slid another hundred-dollar bill from the stack toward herself. Pinning it with one finger, she looked straight into Steve’s eyes and murmured seductively, “I know you liked what you saw. And it was clear your body liked it as well.”

That much was true; no matter how hard Steve tried to control himself, his body had betrayed him, reacting to the tempting offer exactly as Janis had expected.

She continued, “So,” leaning closer to him, opening her dress again, “what do you say we just go to my room up there and have some fun?” Then her finger moved to the money stack again, and she slid another hundred-dollar bill over. “And for this little extra, you can do me any way you like, no limits.”

At that moment, the magic was gone. It was like a fog clearing from his mind. Steve stopped her hand, collected all his money except for the first hundred he’d given her, put it back in his pocket, and said dryly, “Thank you. But I think I’ll pass.”

He stood up and moved toward the door. At the last moment, he turned back and said, “Janis, I meant everything I said before,

and I'll say it again: don't sell yourself short. You can have a great future if you try hard. I wish you all the luck, and I hope you build a successful life for yourself. I really do."

With that, he went outside and walked to his Baby Honō. A moment later, he saw John walking around the side of the diner toward the car.

Ten minutes later, they were back on their way to Los Angeles.

The night stretched quietly ahead of them, the highway a pale ribbon under the moon. For several miles, neither man spoke. The only sound was the steady hum of the engine, faithful, calm, and blessedly uncomplicated.

Chapter 5: The Confession

2:40AM between Winnemucca, NV and Lovelock, NV

"I observe you elected not to accept the young lady's proposals," John remarked once they were back on the highway. He paused briefly, then added, "In fact, you declined both of her offers. I am merely curious as to your reasoning."

Steve was silent. He hadn't expected John to start this conversation. He'd been sure John hadn't seen or heard his exchange with Janis, but now he thought otherwise. He answered plainly,

"I didn't think it was a good idea to bring her along. Our trip's already been a little bumpy, and I didn't want to complicate things. Also, I was pretty sure you would disapprove, considering the whole cloak-and-dagger vibe I'm getting from you."

"Indeed, I concur that having Janis accompany us would have been suboptimal. However, my curiosity persists as to why you refused her second proposition. Judging by your expression back there, you were utterly captivated by her, and I quite expected you to follow her to her room for a much-needed respite. And yet, you abstained. For what reason?"

That was a bizarre conversation, and typically, Steve would have cut it short, firmly and decisively. But the road ahead was still many hours long, and there wasn't much else to talk about. So he decided, *What the hell*, and answered,

"To tell you the truth, I almost took her with us. I was very close to that decision. And yes, her strategy of exposing her naked

body worked exactly as she planned. Her seduction routine was perfect.”

Steve smiled dreamily, as if replaying that encounter in his mind.

“But I felt that our conversation was turning more and more transactional, and I was right. As soon as I showed her that roll of bills, all those theatrics stopped. All that talk about leaving and starting a new life came to a halt. She turned it straight into a business deal: pay me and I’ll fuck you, pay me more and I’ll fuck you without limits.”

Then he added with a tint of regret, “So, in the end, it looks like Janis was just a whore. And somehow, I think we weren’t the first travelers she’s been serving. Her routine was well prepared and rehearsed.”

John replied, “So, I gather you are opposed to paying for carnal services, and you perceive women in that profession as being of a lower class. Am I interpreting you correctly?”

John replied, “So, I gather you are opposed to paying for carnal services, and you perceive women in that profession as being of a lower class. Am I interpreting you correctly?”

“Because of the payment?”

“Because of many things. Money is not an issue.” Steve waved him away. “I’m not that youngster who would jump on any woman who’d let him. Not anymore.” His face grew more serious. “These days, I want to feel something more from the encounter. I want to give pleasure as much as I want to receive it. And when I’m paying for those, what you called *carnal services*, I’d always know in the back

of my mind that all the moaning and groaning was just an act. Also, I'm very particular about my health. It'd be too easy to catch something in the heat of the moment."

"So, you desire affection, wish to remain safe, and prefer the encounter not to feel overtly transactional, correct?"

Steve didn't reply. He was trying to analyze what exactly his position was.

John continued, "Let us postulate a scenario. You go on a date with a woman you met online or through a friend's introduction, a woman with a similarly stimulating appearance as Janis."

"I wouldn't go on a date with a girl that young. She'd have to be at least ten to fifteen years older than Janis."

"Very well, that is a minor detail of no consequence to the hypothetical. So, you have gone on this date with a woman. You invite her to dinner and drinks, and let us assume everything proceeds splendidly. you spend a perfect night together. But afterwards, you are not to see each other ever again, for some reason. Is this a plausible scenario?"

Steve let out a weary exhale. "Yes. Quite plausible. Happened to me a few times recently."

"In that case," John said, "you would most likely spend a great deal more money. You'd have no certainty whether she was feigning her pleasure to bolster your ego, and you'd be unaware of her state of health. Yet you find this to be an acceptable arrangement, while you frown upon the direct transaction."

Steve objected loudly, "Now you're sounding like a chauvinist! You just implied that any woman who goes on a date is a prostitute.

That's insulting and disrespectful. I've never seen it that way, and I never will!" He lowered his voice, continuing, "When I went out with those women, I was actually hoping to meet someone I'd want to see again. But I guess I'm too selective, because in the morning, I'd always end up comparing them to someone who's no longer a part of my life." His tone turned somber.

"Your wife, I take it?" John asked quietly.

"Yeah. My wife."

"Did she walk out on you?"

"No, actually, I was the one who left. I couldn't stay after what happened."

"Were you unfaithful?" John probed.

Steve burst out, "No! Absolutely not. But she was! While I was out working my tail off, doing whatever it took for my family, she was screwing our daughter's friend from college, some young football player. He was barely half her age!"

He couldn't stop now; something inside had broken loose.

"I still don't know how they met or when it began. No idea how long it went on. It only came out because this punk couldn't keep his mouth shut. He started bragging to his buddies about the cougar he was banging and all the wild things she was willing to do in bed!"

"But didn't you sense something was off between you two before you found out? Usually there are signs: changes in behavior in the bedroom, maybe trying out new things, stuff she'd never done before."

“No. Maybe because we weren’t having sex much lately anyway, so everything felt new.”

Steve gripped the steering wheel tighter. “Don’t ask me why. I can’t explain it. It just... happened. We drifted apart over time. On the surface, we still looked like a happy family: friends, parties, trips together. But it wasn’t the same. Something was missing. I buried myself in work. Honestly, I’m damn good at my job. I hoped things would eventually get better between us, but instead, everything fell apart.”

“Do you think you put your job ahead of your family? Or maybe your wife and daughter saw it that way?”

Steve didn’t answer. In the six months since their separation, he’d gone over that question so many times. Every time, he landed on the same thought: his work mattered too much. It paid the bills. Sure, he had to travel a lot and pull a few all-nighters. But everything he did was for their sake, or so he’d kept telling himself.

Now, sitting beside this odd stranger who looked like Clint Eastwood playing James Bond, Steve began to doubt himself.

He remembered the fights about him never being around and missing his daughter’s graduation because he was stuck in Shanghai. All the moments he’d skipped that hadn’t seemed important then.

But maybe they were.

“Maybe,” he muttered. “I honestly don’t know anymore. What I do know is I lost my best friend, my greatest lover, the mother of my kid, and really, the only woman I’ve ever truly loved all these years. And now it’s all gone.”

"Has she moved on? Is she with someone else?" John asked.

"I have no idea."

"Have you tried to patch things up?"

"No. She made her choice when she did what she did."

John fell silent for a moment, then asked softly, "Are you completely sure she was unfaithful? Did you catch her in the act, or find any real evidence: photos, messages, anything? Or did she actually admit it to you?"

* * *

It was late December when Steve guided his car through the cold, dry streets of Bellevue, the Seattle suburb across Lake Washington known as the Eastside. The rare snow from earlier in the week had mainly melted, leaving thin white traces on rooftops and lawns. Holiday lights glittered off the wet asphalt, cheerful and cold against the early dusk.

He'd promised Julia a dinner out tonight, but another crisis had erupted at work that morning. December was always chaos for his team, and today had been no different. He'd called her that afternoon to apologize. She'd said little, her disappointment hanging in the silence between them.

By five o'clock, the emergency had passed. He'd done all he could, and the rest could wait. Guilt pushed him home early.

As he turned onto his street, a spark of warmth replaced the fatigue: Stephanie's car was in the driveway. Their daughter didn't visit often, and he loved it when she did.

He parked behind her and walked to the front door. Inside, the house smelled faintly of cinnamon and wine. Laughter drifted from the entertainment room down the hall, the room they'd once spent evenings in together.

He followed the sound, smiling, until the words reached him.

"Mom, you remember Jack, right?" Stephanie's voice was bright and teasing. "The tall one on the football team? Half the girls on our cheer squad were practically losing it when they saw him."

"Sure, I remember him," Julia said, laughing. "He was quite a specimen."

Steve slowed, curiosity turning to unease.

"We were at a party last night," Stephanie continued. "Jack showed up wasted and started bragging about his latest *catch*. Said he's been screwing some hot MILF for a while now. Called her a real firecracker in bed. Said she lets him do things she'd never let her husband try because he'd think she's a slut."

Stephanie giggled. "Guess she didn't care if *Jack* thought she was one."

"Maybe she was just bored," Julia said lightly. "Left alone too much. And for the record, nobody's ever called me a slut for enjoying sex."

Steve froze behind the corner. His heart began to hammer.

"Mom!" Stephanie laughed. "Can't believe I'm talking about kinky sex with my own mother! But I'm with you. New experiences are fine, as long as nobody gets hurt. Want me to tell you what I tried with my boyfriend last week? You could totally do it with Dad!"

"You youngsters," Julia said, amused. "You think you invented sex. You'd be surprised what your father and I got up to when we were your age."

Her voice softened, a wistful edge creeping in. "But that was long ago."

Steve heard the faint clink of glass as she took a sip.

"So I can understand that *MILF*, as you call her, deciding to have a little fun."

"Mom!" Stephanie gasped. "You're not saying it's *you*, are you? You're screwing Jack!"

For a second, the world tilted. Steve's breath caught; he felt the blood drain from his face.

Julia laughed. "Don't be ridiculous, kiddo. She was supposed to be a *hot cougar*."

"Mom!" Stephanie insisted. "At your age, you look hotter than half the women I know."

"Thank you, sweetheart. You're very kind." Julia's voice hardened. "Too bad your dad stopped seeing me that way."

She sighed. "Even tonight, we were supposed to go to that little restaurant we love, then drive to the treehouse hotel for the weekend. Just us. And what happened? He called to cancel. Work, again. Always work. When he's home, it's still work. Weekends? He hides in the garage, restoring whatever rust bucket he's dragged home."

Her voice wavered. "I feel abandoned. Alone. Discarded. Sure, he buys me gifts; bags, jewelry, that AMG roadster because he

knows I love to drive fast, but maybe what I want is something else.”

The anger bled into sorrow.

“Maybe I just want him *here*. To see me. To touch me. To love me the way he used to.”

A long silence. Then Stephanie asked softly, “Mom... are you sleeping with Jack?”

Steve stepped into the doorway.

“Yeah, Julia,” he said quietly. “I’d like to know that too. Are you sleeping with Jack?”

* * *

Steve fell quiet, hands gripping the wheel as if speech itself had become too heavy.

John gave him space, watching the dark ribbon of road ahead. After a while, he asked softly, “Did she confess?”

Steve exhaled. “If you mean, did she actually say yes or no? No, she never did. The whole thing blew up into a massive argument about our life together, and no matter how many times I pressed her, she just wouldn’t give me an answer. She knew it was tearing me apart and still wouldn’t say a word. So I told her that if she wouldn’t say yes or no, then by default, I’d assume yes.”

He shot John a glance. “We had this rule, years back; always answer honestly when the question is yes or no. For decades, I never doubted her. Sure, we both sidestepped hard questions now and then, but we never lied. ‘Yes’ meant ‘yes,’ ‘no’ meant ‘no.’ Simple.”

He turned his gaze back to the road. "Maybe I'm the fool. Maybe she'd been lying for years, and I just didn't want to see it. Anyway, I left that night. Been separated since, divorce's nearly final."

John, unruffled as ever, asked, "Was she justified?"

Steve frowned. "In what way?"

"In claiming you'd withdrawn from her life. You gave her gifts, holidays, comfort, but were you truly present?"

"Yes," Steve said quickly.

"Are you certain? Think before you answer."

The hum of the tires filled the silence. Ten long minutes passed.

Steve's mind wandered through the years. The cramped apartment where he and Julia started, the night Stephanie was born, the years of struggle that became success. Somewhere along the way, something had shifted. He could feel it now, driving through the darkness with this strange, unflappable man beside him.

"Maybe I wasn't around like I used to be," he admitted quietly.

"I daresay you were not," John replied, his tone almost kind. "Now, tell me, what do you want your future to hold? You could chase more triumphs at work. That would be easy enough; you've the time for it now. But to what end? What are you truly hoping to achieve?"

Steve opened his mouth, then stopped. He had no answer.

John went on, his voice measured. "By your own admission, your recent dates have been hollow, and it's clearly not for lack of capacity or opportunity. You're still searching for the woman you let slip away."

Steve started to object, but John raised a hand. "Indeed, you let her go. Perhaps even pushed her away without realising it."

"I don't know," Steve muttered.

John waited a beat, then said quietly, "From where I stand, you have only a few paths left. One: begin again. Leave the past behind, find someone new, and strive not to repeat your mistakes, though it's rarely simple past a certain age.

"Two: dwell in bitterness. Keep reliving the humiliation until resentment corrodes everything else. You'll still have good days, of course: success at work, another car project, but the emptiness will grow.

"Or three: make peace. Accept what's happened, learn from it, and, if possible, reach out to the woman who still seems to matter more than you'd like to admit. Who may never even have done what you think she did."

He turned his eyes toward the windshield's reflection, calm as glass. "No need for an answer now. The decision, as ever, is yours."

Chapter 6: The Lodging

3:30AM near Lovelock, NV

They had been travelling in silence for nearly an hour. The highway unfurled endlessly ahead, an empty ribbon glinting under the headlights. Steve was lost in thought while John sat perfectly still beside him, his gaze fixed forward as if carved from stone. The man barely seemed to breathe.

Drowsiness crept up on Steve, softening the edges of the world and making it distant. His eyelids grew heavy, the hum of the tires hypnotic. He knew the signs too well; this was the dangerous stage, when the brain began shutting down, but the eyes stayed open.

He gave a slight shake of his head, breaking the stillness.

"John, I've got to pull over. I'm starting to drift off with my eyes wide open, and that never ends well."

John turned toward him with unshaken composure. "And what do you propose, good sir? Are you suggesting I should take the wheel?"

Steve barked a quick laugh and shook his head.

"No way. Absolutely not." When John arched a brow, Steve added, "I'd never get real rest with someone else driving at night. I'd just keep thinking you'd nod off too, and we'd both be toast. The only person I ever trusted to drive me isn't around anymore."

"So once more it comes down to control?" John asked mildly, a flicker of amusement ghosting over his face.

Steve sighed. "Fine. Call it a control thing." He loosened his grip on the wheel and eased off the gas. "I'll find a hotel or motel,

anywhere I can crash for a couple of hours. That's all I need. I'll grab a shower, throw on a clean shirt," he nodded toward the suitcase in the backseat, "and I'll be good for another round."

John gave a slight, noncommittal shrug and said nothing more.

Ten minutes later, they pulled into a gas station, one of those lonely outposts that never fully closed, just dimmed itself down for the night. The fluorescent lights buzzed faintly; a desert wind stirred the paper trash caught along the fence.

While Steve filled Baby Honō's tank, John wandered off toward the restroom. Steve slipped an AirPods into his ear and began scrolling through every motel on his map, pacing slow circles around the cracked asphalt to keep himself awake.

By the time John returned, Steve looked both puzzled and irritated. "Every single hotel and motel's full. Not one room available! I called every last one." He gave a crooked smile. "Must be a damn convention for insomniacs."

John didn't appear concerned. "I am content as I am," he said evenly. "We could keep going, or I could take over if you permitted. But if you'd like to sample rural Nevada hospitality..." He gestured toward a billboard above the highway, its paint bleached and cracked under the harsh lights.

The sign read: **FRIENDLY LODGING.**

Below, a phone number and simple directions: *Next exit left, then down the road.*

Steve squinted up at it. "Alright, let's see if they've got two rooms, or one with two beds."

"I will remain with the car while you rest," John replied, already turning away. "If sleep overtakes me, I shall manage it here."

Something in his tone gave Steve pause, a faint warning buried under courtesy, but he shrugged it off and dialed the number.

The line rang for nearly half a minute before someone picked up. A rasping female voice snapped, "What do you want?"

He smiled to himself. "Hi there. I saw your sign on the highway and was hoping to book a room for tonight."

"You want a room?" she repeated, her irritation fading to something like curiosity.

"Yes. Do you have anything available?"

"I got some beds, if you don't mind sharin'," she muttered.

"I'd prefer private," Steve said, keeping his tone polite but firm.

In the background, another voice called out, "Dora, you done? There are people waiting!"

"Let 'em wait!" she barked back. Then, into the phone: "Yeah, I got one single left, but it's extra. Seventy-five bucks."

"I'll take it," Steve said quickly. "Can I pay now? So that it's locked in?"

"Fine. Gimme your number."

Steve opened his banking app, generated a one-time card number, and read it off. "Name's Steve Kova."

A pause. Then the faint sound of a register printing. "Alright, Steve Kova. You're paid up. Knock on the door when you get here. I'll let you in." The line went dead with a soft click.

He chuckled and slipped his phone away. The weirdest people ran night lodgings out here, but a bed was a bed. Climbing back behind the wheel, he fired up the Honda.

“Let’s check this place out,” he said, trying to sound upbeat. “Just two hours of sleep and I’ll be brand new.”

John glanced at him once, expression unreadable. “Let us hope the place is as *friendly* as it claims.”

Steve laughed. The sound died quickly in the empty night as Baby Honō rolled back onto the highway.

The billboard lights vanished behind them, swallowed by the dark Nevada plain. Ahead, the road stretched on, thin, pale, and endless.

* * *

3:45 AM near Lovelock, NV

They turned down a narrow dirt lane, headlights slicing through the dark. When the GPS announced “Destination on the right,” Steve’s stomach tightened. Whatever he had imagined, it wasn’t this.

The house crouched in the middle of a barren field like a relic no one had bothered to bury. Its siding was the color of old dust, the porch sagged with exhaustion, and the gravel drive was a patchwork of weeds and oil stains. Two warped gates leaned inward, their chains hanging loose, as if even thieves had long ago decided there was nothing left worth stealing.

The place looked dead, yet scattered lights flickered faintly across the yard. Three semi-trucks and a handful of cars were parked neatly on a small gravel patch near the road, probably belonging to other guests. But just beyond the gate, something made Steve blink. A spotless 1990 BMW M635CSi stood there like it had rolled out of a museum. Its white paint glowed bone-pale under the moon, chrome wheels flashing cold reflections. The sight was absurd, a shrine to perfection surrounded by decay.

Beyond the fence, the porch stretched wide and uneven. One rocker lay tipped over, the other creaked gently in the wind, keeping time with some invisible rhythm. The windows were opaque with grime, the porch light long dead, leaving only moonlight to trace pale streaks across the wall.

To the right, an old RV leaned into the wind, its beige skin flaking in long curls. A man sat in a folding chair beside it, maybe in his fifties or sixties, the red coal of his joint glowing each time he inhaled. He exhaled a long plume of smoke that drifted their way, carrying the heavy, earthy scent of weed. It was legal in Nevada, but out here it only made the place feel stranger, more detached from the world.

Inside the yard, half-dismantled cars sat like fossil bones, hoods open, bumpers gone. Behind them, a few crooked plywood sheds hunched together at odd angles, their outlines vaguely human in the fading moonlight.

Steve shut off Baby Hono's engine. Silence dropped over them, thick and absolute. Dust floated briefly in the headlights before

melting into shadow. “No freaking way this is it,” he muttered, eyes fixed on that flawless BMW, an altar of care surrounded by neglect.

John leaned forward, studying the house through the windshield with the same unreadable calm. Something in his eyes flickered once, like he recognized the place or found it amusing, but he said nothing.

Every instinct told Steve to turn around, yet pride held him fast. He wasn’t about to let John see him spooked. Before stepping out, he reached for one of the empty Red Bull cans in the back seat and crushed it tightly between his hands. Sliding it into the inside pocket of his jacket, he zipped it up halfway. The metal bulge pressed just enough to look like a concealed weapon. A small insurance policy in case this “lodging” turned out to be less than friendly.

John noticed, gave him a faint grin, and still said nothing.

Steve opened the door. The hinges creaked loudly in the quiet. Gravel crunched under his boots, and the desert air bit dry and metallic. Behind him, the keys swung gently in the ignition, catching the moonlight like a silent warning.

* * *

3:45 AM - 4:10 AM near Lovelock, NV

Steve climbed out of the car, stepped over the sagging chain, and rehearsed his approach the way he used to before a difficult meeting.

The plan was simple: act calm, act like he belonged here.

He walked from the gate to the porch with steady purpose. Up close, the house looked even worse. The steps were cracked, the boards soft under his weight. No doorbell, only a mark where one had been and a single wire hanging loose.

"You oughta just bang on it," called the man by the RV, voice lazy and amused. "Someone'll let you in."

"I'm looking for Dora," Steve said, keeping his tone businesslike.

The man laughed. "Then you better bang harder. Dora's busy banging her johns. There's a line, so wait your turn."

Steve ignored him and knocked.

Footsteps shuffled inside. The door opened a few inches, and a hoarse female voice rasped, "Who the hell are you and what do you want?"

"The person who booked a room with Dora about twenty minutes ago. Are you Dora?"

A throaty laugh answered him. "No, I'm Silver. Dora's occupied, but her regular's a quick shot, so she'll be free soon."

Silver swung the door wider. The smell hit first: alcohol, weed, and stale air. She was of no clear age, cheeks flushed, grin full of gaps. A faded dress hung off her frame like a rag. Her hair, roughly dyed and uneven, was at least clean.

Behind her, a few heavy men sprawled around a low table, bottles and smoke between them. They stared at Steve without expression.

He kept his face blank. "I had an agreement with Dora for a room."

Even as he said it, he knew he wasn't staying.

Then he sensed movement behind him. The RV man had stepped closer, cutting off retreat. Two of the drinkers rose from the couch and stood behind Silver.

Running now would mean climbing the chain, starting the car, all while they were on him.

He straightened his shoulders. "If Dora is busy, you can show me to my room, please."

Silver stuck out a hand. "Fifty bucks."

"I paid Dora already," Steve said evenly.

She cackled. "You paid for the room, sweetheart. But extras cost extra. Fifty and you can have me any way you want. Your buddy in the car can watch for another fifty."

"Room only," Steve said, his voice turning cold. "No extras. No distractions."

"Suit yourself." She waved toward the yard. "Rooms without service are out back."

She brushed past him and gestured for him to follow. The two big men trailed behind.

As they rounded the corner, Silver pointed to a tiny plywood shack. "Bathroom's that one. If you only gotta pee, use the bushes."

A garden hose hung from a tap with a towel on a nail. "Shower's here. Hope you don't mind an audience." She laughed, hiked her dress, and flashed her naked, formless bottom to the

followers, earning catcalls. "See? I don't. I'm clean. Washing after each john. Dora's the dirty one, showers once a week, disgusting."

Steve nodded faintly.

Behind the house, three men in matching black Adidas tracksuits sat under a yellow lamp, playing cards beside a bottle of vodka. They spoke in rapid Slavic. Steve caught a few familiar words but not the meaning.

Snoring came from nearby huts. The whole place reeked of sweat, smoke, and rot.

Silver led him to a shack patched from plywood panels. She pulled aside the rag that served as a curtain. "Here's your room." She smiled crookedly. "And if you or your friend changes your mind, just holler. Have the fifty ready."

"Thanks," Steve said. He adjusted his jacket so the crushed Red Bull can inside formed a solid bulge. The gesture was slow and deliberate, the kind men made when checking a weapon.

He looked her in the eye. "I'll park my car next to the room."

"That's another ten," she said, palm open. "Gate hasn't moved in years, though, probably rusted solid."

Steve had sorted his cash earlier; he pulled a single bill from the right pocket and handed it over.

Then he turned to the two men blocking his way. "Do you mind helping me open the gate? I'll drive inside."

The larger one grinned. "Ten each."

Steve's jaw tightened, then he smiled slightly, pulled two tens from another pocket, and placed them in the man's hand. "Deal."

He walked back toward the chain with measured calm. The crowd watched him, waiting. Even the card players had come to see what happened next.

Steve climbed over the chain, slid into Baby Hono, and started the engine. The headlights cut across the yard. For a moment, everyone froze in the glare.

Instead of waiting, Steve dropped the gear into reverse and hit the gas. The Honda shot backward, gravel spraying. He spun the wheel, braked, swung the car around in a tight half-circle, shifted to first, and floored it again.

The little red car tore down the highway, its taillights shrinking fast, leaving the porch, the laughter, and Silver's shouts swallowed in the desert dark.

* * *

4:20 AM near Lovelock, NV

John broke the silence first. "You are a courageous fellow," he said with that measured calm of his. "Marching into the lion's den like that. I suspect your little trick with the can wouldn't have fooled them for long. Sooner or later, someone would have tested it."

"I know," Steve said, keeping his tone casual. "But that was the only card I had. Once that door opened, backing out wasn't an option. I just acted like I belonged there, like nothing scared me. If they thought I planned to stay, they'd relax long enough for me to find an excuse to get back to the car."

He smiled faintly. "At least now I'm wide awake. Probably just the adrenaline, but when it fades, I might actually let you drive."

John's mouth curved in a dry smile. "It is an honor that you would trust me behind the wheel."

"Don't mention it," Steve laughed.

They drove a while without speaking. The highway stretched empty ahead, the desert moon riding low. Then John said, "You are a curious man, Steve. You fret over trivial things, yet in the face of real danger, you show genuine courage and cleverness." He paused, almost amused. "Unless, of course, you were simply unaware of how grave the situation truly was. In that case, I must credit good fortune for saving you the trouble of my intervention."

Steve caught the faint edge of superiority in his tone but let it pass. "I had a plan. That's what the can was for. I scoped things out, came up with a strategy, and stuck to it. It worked. Most of them were too high to care. The ones that bothered me were those three guys in the Adidas tracksuits. I got a bad feeling from them."

John nodded once. "Yes, I quite agree. Let us hope we never meet them again."

The car rolled on, engine humming steadily into the dark.

* * *

4:50 - 5:15 AM near Lovelock, NV

They drove in silence, Steve replaying everything that had happened while John sat motionless, eyes fixed on the road ahead.

After a while, John said, "Steve, would you object to a brief respite? I find I must stretch my legs and avail myself of the facilities."

"Sure thing," Steve replied. "Not sure what kind of bathrooms they've got around here, but I'll pull over when I see one."

"My sincerest gratitude."

Steve checked his phone. "There's a rest area three miles ahead. We're in luck."

He turned off the highway and into a small, deserted stop, just a few picnic tables and a restroom building lit by a single yellow lamp.

"You go first," he told John. "I'll stay with the car."

John nodded and disappeared inside.

Steve stepped out, walked to the trees, and relieved himself. The air was cold but clear, the kind that tasted faintly of pine. The moon hung high, washing the lot in silvery light. When he finished, he gathered the trash from the car, tossed it away, and, almost ceremonially, dropped the crushed Red Bull can in after it.

He raised the hood to check the oil.

That was when he heard another engine.

A car pulled in, its headlights sweeping across the pavement before cutting out. A white BMW rolled to a stop behind Baby Hono, blocking the exit. Steve's gut tightened.

It was the immaculate M635 from Dora's place.

The Adidas trio stepped out.

He straightened, slid his jacket off, and threw it on the roof of the Honda. A coat could get tangled in a fight. He took a few steps

back, grounding himself on the asphalt, back to the restroom building. John was still inside.

The driver grinned. "Privet. You left fast, suka. Didn't even let me check your car. Prelude, ninety-five, da?"

Steve kept his voice steady. "Yeah. Good year for the Prelude."

"VTEC?"

"Yep."

"Four-wheel steering?"

"Yep."

"Nice." The man stepped closer, still smiling. "By the way, I'm Misha."

"Steve," he said, shaking his hand, careful to look relaxed.

Misha nodded toward his BMW. "Got that one for nothing. We stopped at a place like this, took it. We'll do the same with your Honda. So, be smart, blyad. Hand over the keys. Maybe we'll let you keep your suitcase, after we check."

Two of his cronies spread out slightly, each gripping a baseball bat.

Steve's breath shortened. His heart pounded in his ears. The faces in front of him blurred, replaced by others: boys from his childhood back in Sarajevo, smirking, jeering, pushing him into the dirt. The old helplessness clawed at his chest.

Steve froze for a second, trembling. Then something changed.

He told himself, "You spent your whole life training to fight bullies like this. So tonight you'll apply your skills. For real."

Steve exhaled slowly, letting the fear burn itself out. His vision cleared. He locked eyes with Misha. Enough.

He shifted his weight, then exploded forward, driving his fist square into Misha's nose. Bone cracked. Blood sprayed.

Misha reeled backward, shouting, "Suka, blyad, you broke my nose!"

Before the others could react, Steve stepped in and delivered a sharp kick to Misha's jaw. The thug collapsed flat, out cold.

The two with bats hesitated, startled. Steve circled, keeping both in front of him. The first swung. Steve slipped aside, countered with a punch to the face, then stepped back, keeping them aligned so they couldn't flank him.

The second one yelled something in Russian, but his courage faltered. They weren't used to people fighting back.

A shadow moved across the asphalt. John was walking toward them, calm as ever, the moonlight glinting off his cufflinks.

One thug barked, "Hey, Sam, look, it's that clown in the suit, blyad!"

John didn't answer. He reached into his briefcase, and the pistol with a silencer appeared in his left hand. Two muted cracks echoed through the lot. Both bats splintered in their owners' hands. They froze, staring in shock.

Misha groaned on the ground, reaching for his waistband.

John's voice sliced through the air, precise, icy. "Don't even think about it. I'll put a bullet between your eyes before you draw."

That sound, the soft pop of the silenced gun, hit Steve like a hammer.

The world folded in on itself. The smell of oil and pine turned into smoke and dust. Screams. The whistle of shells. A child's cry

was cut short.

He saw the narrow street again, the building collapsing in slow motion.

Then the silence. The kind of silence that only snipers leave behind.

For a few seconds, he couldn't breathe. Couldn't see.

Then, with monumental effort, he tore himself back into the present.

John was beside him now, calm and unhurried. "Very slowly," he said to Misha, "using two fingers, remove your weapon and cast it aside."

Misha obeyed, trembling. His eyes darted between Steve and John, calculating.

"The rest of you, on the ground," John ordered.

Both dropped instantly.

Without taking his eyes off them, John asked quietly, "Do you know how to handle one of these?"

"Yeah," Steve said. His voice came out thin but steady.

John handed him the pistol and drew several white zip ties from his briefcase. Steve covered the men, but as he shifted his grip, despite hours of training on the range, his finger brushed the trigger.

The pistol cracked once, the bullet slapping the pavement between the thugs.

John didn't blink. "Kindly refrain from theatrics. I believe they understand us now."

Steve swallowed hard. "Yeah. Sorry."

John moved efficiently, binding Misha and Sam. Then he picked up Misha's discarded pistol, field-stripped it in seconds, pocketed the spring, wiped the rest, and scattered the parts into the darkness.

He turned to the last thug. "You. Push your car back. Then join your friends on the ground."

When the BMW cleared the way, John said, "We're done here."

They climbed into the Honda. John leaned out the window. "Do not follow us. You have tools, yes? Use them, after we're gone."

He raised the pistol and fired twice, blowing out the BMW's tires, then set it back into the briefcase.

Steve gunned the engine. Baby Honō roared to life and tore away down the empty Nevada highway, the rest stop vanishing in the rearview mirror.

* * *

5:20 AM near Lovelock, NV

As the red Prelude merged back onto the highway, leaving the shattered rest area behind, Steve finally exploded.

"What the hell was that? What's with the gun? Who the fuck are you, John? You owe me an explanation!"

John, perfectly composed, said, "I owe you nothing. You found yourself in a predicament, and I took the most efficient measures to correct it."

"I was handling it! Misha was down, and the other two had lost their nerve. I could've taken care of them."

"And been shot in the back by Misha for your trouble."

Steve gripped the wheel. "Maybe, maybe not. But you started shooting. You could've killed them!"

"Incorrect. I discharged my firearm four times. Two rounds into their tyres, two into their bats."

"Moving bats. Moving right in front of their faces."

"Trifling details," John replied calmly. "The point is that I fired four shots under complete control. It was you, rather, who nearly killed one of them because you violated the simplest rule of firearm safety: keep your finger off the trigger."

"Stop changing the subject!" Steve snapped. "You still haven't told me who you are or what the hell is going on!"

"And I have no intention of doing so," John answered. "I engaged your services to drive me to Los Angeles. I paid the agreed-upon sum. I don't recall any clause requiring me to share information of a classified nature."

Steve drew a long breath, forcing his voice steady. "I think we're done here. We need to part ways. I'll drive to the next town with a used-car lot, give you your money back, hell, I'll even buy you another car myself. Then you can go wherever you want, and I'll head home. Deal?"

John's tone softened slightly. "That is remarkably generous. I'm not being facetious, I mean it. If you're willing to assist me that way, I'd be most grateful. One point, though. I won't take my payment back, nor will I accept a vehicle bought by you. I have ample funds."

He paused, studying the dark ribbon of highway ahead. "But let us not be hasty. It will be hours before we find any dealership open for business. Until then, we may as well continue on our original route. Agreed?"

Steve couldn't find a hole in the reasoning. He grunted his assent and turned his attention back to the road.

The highway stretched out under the pale desert moon, empty and endless, the silence between them thicker than ever.

Chapter 7: The Exchange

11:00 AM near China Lake, CA

Steve was dreaming. It was a gentle, sun-washed dream filled with laughter and the faint aroma of coffee drifting through his childhood kitchen. He was home again, back in Sarajevo, a cheerful, bookish teenager named Stipe Kovačević, who still believed computers could fix the world. His parents were there, younger than he was now, smiling at him from the small balcony where they used to sit on summer evenings. His little sister stood nearby, but her face refused to come into focus. He knew she was there, could sense her presence, yet her features stayed stubbornly blurred, as though memory itself couldn't bear to recall her clearly.

Then, the light shifted. The quiet afternoon dissolved into smoke and thunder. He stood before the ruins of what had once been their home. The familiar windows were shattered, the walls torn apart, everything buried under gray dust. Somewhere beneath that wreckage were his parents and his sister, gone forever. The shelling of Sarajevo had claimed them. Even after thirty years, the ache had never left him. The sound of distant artillery, the crack of sniper fire cutting down ordinary people in the streets, still lived in his bones.

The nightmare twisted once more. Suddenly, he was behind the wheel, speeding down a dark road, headlights slicing through blackness. His hands gripped the steering wheel, but his eyes refused to open. Panic surged as he realized he was asleep at the wheel. A strangled scream tore from his throat as he jerked awake.

For a few disoriented moments, Steve couldn't tell what was real. Then, clarity returned. He wasn't driving. He was in the passenger seat, his heart still hammering in his chest.

He remembered now. At some point during the night, he had finally agreed to let John drive. Part of it was curiosity. He wanted to see how the man would manage it, chained to that ever-present briefcase. Somehow, John had made it work, shifting gears with the same eerie precision that seemed to define everything about him. After that, Steve had closed his eyes for just a second, and that second had stretched into hours.

Now, Baby Honō was slowing as John guided her toward a gas station.

Steve blinked the sleep from his eyes, stretched, and stepped out of the car. Cool morning air hit his face. He checked his watch and blinked in disbelief: it was almost eleven. He'd slept for over six hours. The landscape looked different now, flatter and brighter. They must have crossed into California.

John was nowhere to be seen. Steve assumed he had gone to the restroom, so he started the fuel pump himself. When the nozzle clicked off, signaling the tank was full, Steve replaced it and leaned against the car, gazing toward the horizon.

A thought crossed his mind: simple, tempting, and shameful.

He could just get in the driver's seat and go.

Leave John here.

Let him find his own way to Los Angeles.

The man was resourceful; he'd manage. It wasn't like he couldn't hitch a ride or rent a car. Steve could be miles away before

John even realized he was gone.

But the idea made his stomach turn. He prided himself on keeping his word, and ditching John now, after everything, felt wrong. Dishonorable, even.

Still, the thought lingered as he climbed behind the wheel. Only then did he notice, the keys weren't in the ignition.

John had taken them when he stepped out.

Steve chuckled under his breath. Whether by accident or design, John had made the decision for him. They would continue this strange journey together.

Moments later, John reappeared, his expression unreadable. Without a word, he opened the driver's door, sat down, and placed the keys back into the ignition.

Steve started the engine, glanced at him, and said, "We've only got a few hours left on this trip. Doesn't make much sense for you to buy another car now. I'll drive you to the end point, as agreed."

John gave a faint nod, eyes fixed on the road ahead.

Baby Honō rolled forward once more, her red paint glinting beneath the California sun as the two unlikely travelers continued south toward Los Angeles.

* * *

2:20PM - 3:30PM near Glendale, CA

The afternoon sun baked the highway as the red Prelude sliced through the hazy outskirts of Los Angeles. The air shimmered over the asphalt, and palm trees swayed lazily beyond the concrete dividers.

“Where exactly in LA are we heading?” Steve asked, glancing at the navigation display as they neared the exit for Vincent.

John’s reply came smoothly and precisely. “Let us make a brief stop in Glendale. Afterward, I believe the Griffith Observatory would serve as a fitting location for our farewell.”

Steve grinned. “That’s pretty poetic,” he said, then added, “So what’s in Glendale?”

“I believe it would be prudent for you to part ways with Baby Honō,” John answered. “Quite a few unsavory individuals have taken notice of it during our travels. That could attract unwelcome attention later. You’re fond of the car, certainly, but I suspect you’d trade it soon enough anyway.”

Steve gave it a moment’s thought and nodded. “You might be right. She’s been great, but I’ve done everything to her I can think of. Honestly, I was planning to swap her out once I got back from Idaho.”

“Excellent,” John said, his tone as calm as ever. “I happen to know a used car dealer who is as trustworthy as one could hope for in that profession. He has a fondness for classics like this Honda.”

Steve arched a brow. “A trustworthy used car dealer? That’s a rare species. What’s his name?”

“Tigran.”

John reached into his briefcase, as effortlessly as always, and produced a business card without even glancing down. He handed it over with quiet precision. “You’ll find his establishment in Glendale.”

Steve entered the address into his phone, then looked at the map. "All right. Since this might be my last drive with Baby Honō, how about we take the scenic route? There's this incredible canyon road I know. You'll love it."

John's gaze remained on the horizon. "And what precisely makes it remarkable?"

Steve chuckled. "Hard to explain. It's more of a feeling thing. Trust me, it'll stick with you."

"I'm quite content without sentimental experiences," John replied coolly, "but I won't object either. Proceed however you wish."

Steve smirked, downshifted, and steered toward the canyon exit. The Prelude's engine purred as the highway gave way to winding curves and golden hills.

It felt, somehow, like the beginning of a goodbye.

* * *

3:40PM - 4:15PM near Glendale, CA

The little red Honda tore through the canyon, its engine singing as it hugged the winding asphalt. The rear wheels threw up gravel and dust, sunlight flickering across the windshield as the car drifted through each curve in perfect rhythm.

Steve was completely locked in. Everything else: John, the journey, even the world itself, fell away until it was just him, Baby Honō, and the road. The tires gripped, the gears clicked, and the

steering wheel felt alive under his hands. He accelerated hard out of one turn, then braked into the next, chasing that razor-thin line between control and chaos.

When he finally stole a glance at John, the man sat perfectly upright, one hand resting near the briefcase, gaze fixed on the road ahead. But there it was, a faint, unmistakable smile tugging at the corner of his mouth. For once, the unflappable John seemed... human.

That was all the encouragement Steve needed. He pushed harder, trusting every inch of the machine he'd rebuilt with his own hands. The car responded beautifully, sliding through another tight bend, its VTEC engine roaring in satisfaction. For a brief, glorious moment, Steve felt weightless, like the world had opened up beneath him and he could go anywhere.

Then, just as suddenly, it was over. The road widened, the city appeared ahead, and civilization reclaimed the silence. Steve eased off the gas, pulled over, and let out a long, shaky breath. The rush drained from his veins, leaving only the hum of the idling engine.

John spoke first. "You handled yourself admirably just now," he said, his tone almost approving. "Have you ever competed in rally racing?"

Steve laughed, shaking his head. "Only against Julia. She beat me every time. She was fearless, really knew how to handle a car." His smile faded. "We used to take turns navigating for each other. Those were good days."

John said nothing. The quiet between them carried more weight than words could.

After a while, Steve restarted the engine. "I think we should hit a car wash before we see your guy, Tigran, right? I want top dollar for Baby Honō. She deserves to look flawless on her last day."

John replied without looking at him. "He is not my acquaintance. I have never met him."

Steve frowned. "Then how do you even know he exists?"

John's gaze stayed fixed on the passing hills. "I simply do."

* * *

5:45PM Glendale, CA

Classic Treasure Cars had the familiar layout of a used car lot, but none of its usual mediocrity. A compact stucco office sat out front, its parking spaces neatly lined and surrounded by two dozen cars gleaming under the late-afternoon sun. Their hoods stood open in practiced display, with prices painted boldly across windshields and small, handwritten cards boasting details about careful restorations, rare trims, and one-owner histories.

Colorful banners swayed lazily above them: *We Smash LA's Prices, Cash for Your Old Ride, No Questions Asked, Today Only: Free Air Freshener with Every Purchase.*

Steve chuckled when he spotted his favorite: *Still Kind of a Fourth of July Blowout!*, which felt especially funny since Independence Day had come and gone nearly three weeks ago.

For all its modesty, the place had taste. Every car looked meticulously maintained; there were no sun-faded sedans or half-

broken junkers here. The lot felt more like a private collection than a dealership. There were pristine imports from the eighties and nineties, each one worthy of a second glance: a Toyota Supra, a Mazda RX-7, and even a right-hand-drive Nissan Skyline GTR R32 that gleamed like a silver bullet in the fading light.

Steve eased Baby Honō into a spot in front of the office and turned to John.

“Hey, want to come in and meet Tigran?”

John straightened his sleeve and replied in that composed, aristocratic tone.

“No, I believe I shall take a short stroll about the premises and admire his inventory. You go ahead. I’ll have a look around.”

Steve smirked. “Sure thing. Don’t go buying another briefcase while I’m gone.”

A hint of amusement flickered across John’s face. “Heaven forbid. One is already quite enough.”

Steve laughed, shut off the engine, and stepped out into the warm evening air. The lot smelled faintly of polish and gasoline, that particular scent every car lover secretly adored. He gave Baby Honō one last glance, then headed toward the glass door of the office, where a buzzing neon *OPEN* sign glowed faintly in the amber light of the Glendale sunset.

* * *

5:45PM - 6:30PM Glendale, CA

By the time Steve reached the office, the door swung open, and a man emerged, walking toward him with deliberate, measured steps. He was wiry, in his seventies, every movement sharp and efficient. His eyes, dark, intelligent, and alive, took Steve in with the scrutiny of a jeweler examining a rare stone. Years under the Southern California sun had traced fine lines across his olive-toned face. Still, his posture remained proud, shoulders squared beneath a worn gray blazer layered over a burgundy sweater.

A faint scent of motor oil and strong coffee followed him, the kind that never thoroughly washes off after a lifetime spent among engines and handshakes. His thinning silver hair was slicked neatly back, and his expression carried that unmistakable mix of welcome and calculation, someone who'd seen every trick and maybe invented a few of his own.

"Hello, welcome to Classic Treasure Cars," he said with a smile that hovered somewhere between warmth and appraisal. "I am Tigran, the owner of this oasis of rare beauties."

Steve shook his hand. "Nice to meet you, Tigran. I'm Steve."

"So, Steve," Tigran began, his accent still carrying a trace of Yerevan mellowed by forty years of Glendale. "What brings you here? You look like a man who misses the days when cars were real machines, not smartphones on wheels."

Steve laughed. "Exactly. They just don't make 'em like they used to. I'm actually looking to find a new home for my ride." He nodded toward Baby Honō. "She's been great, but it's time to move on, if the price is right."

Tigran's gaze followed the gesture. "Prelude? Maybe ninety-eight, ninety-nine? Not exactly rare or valuable. I'm not sure I'd be interested at all. I have standards here."

Steve raised an eyebrow. "It's an Si VTEC."

Tigran shook his head slowly. "That doesn't add up. There are Si Preludes and there are VTEC Preludes, but no Si VTEC, at least not in the U.S. If yours says that, it's probably a fake badge."

Steve grinned. "You know your Preludes, I'll give you that. But this one's a short-run import. Never said it was a U.S. model."

Tigran rubbed his chin. "Hmm. You know, I hear stories like that all the time. People bring me cars and tell me all kinds of fairy tales. Still," he took a step closer to the car, eyeing it from front to back ", if you're serious about selling, I'll offer you ten grand."

Steve didn't blink. "You've seen what these go for, right? Restored ones like this easily hit forty these days."

"All my cars are fully restored," Tigran replied dryly.

"Exactly," Steve said. "So you know what I'm talking about. I'll let her go for thirty."

Tigran strolled around Baby Honō, brushing his fingertips over the flawless paint, then pulled a small gadget from his pocket to scan the panels for hidden repairs. The device stayed silent. After a minute, he straightened up. "Thirteen grand."

Steve threw up his hands. "That's an insult to Mr. Honda himself! This car has upgraded suspension, a custom exhaust, and a full service history, the works. Twenty-eight."

"Probably done by some backyard amateur," Tigran said flatly.

“Nope,” Steve countered. “Built by a performance shop in Seattle.”

Tigran snorted. “Seattle? Please. Real shops are in LA. Still, I like how you talk. Eighteen grand, final offer.”

“Twenty-five,” Steve shot back.

“Eighteen,” Tigran said again, unshaken. “You have the title on hand?”

Steve pulled out his phone and showed him a photo of the document. “Here you go. I can overnight the real one if we agree on twenty-four.”

Tigran groaned and threw his hands up. “You don’t even have it with you? Eighteen’s my last offer. Fifteen minutes only. After that, it’s fifteen.”

Steve was about to walk away when he noticed John standing a few yards off, giving him a subtle nod toward another car. Steve turned back to Tigran. “Hang on, my friend wants me to check something. I’ll be right back.”

“Fourteen minutes left,” Tigran called after him with a grin.

Steve joined John, who silently pointed toward a silver car gleaming under the fading sun. Steve’s pulse quickened: it was a first-generation 2001 Audi TT Quattro convertible, identical to the one he’d owned years ago. Seeing it felt like running into an old friend.

He circled the car, taking in every curve, then slid into the red baseball-glove leather seats. The interior was immaculate, the aluminum trim gleaming like new. He dropped the top, letting the light pour in, and for a moment, everything felt just right.

He crouched behind the car, checked underneath, then popped the hood, running his hands along the key areas only someone who knew this model inside out would examine. The price on the windshield read \$19,000.

Then glanced at the VIN number under the corner of the windshield. That was all he needed to see.

He strode back to the office. "That TT out there? What shape's it in?"

Tigran looked amused. "Every car here is pristine."

"Timing belt and water pump?"

"Both replaced ten thousand miles ago."

"Ignition system?"

"Brand new."

"Water leak into the CCM?"

"Never," Tigran replied smoothly.

Steve crossed his arms. "How do I know you're not just saying that?"

"I've got paperwork for everything," Tigran said. "Full history: from the factory in Hungary to this lot. You can read every page if you want."

Steve nodded once. "Straight swap. My Prelude for the TT."

Tigran tilted his head. "Plus the difference. TT's nineteen grand."

Steve pulled out what cash he had left and held it out. "Here, whatever this comes to. You already know this is a good deal for you. Don't make me haggle over a few hundred bucks."

Tigran hesitated, then smiled and slipped the bills into his jacket. "Deal. We'll finish inside. But remember, send me that title quick, or my cousins in Seattle might come asking about it, understand?"

Steve grinned, shaking his hand. "Fair enough. You have my word."

His thinning silver hair was neatly slicked back, and there was an odd mix of welcome and cautiousness in his look, the gaze of someone who'd witnessed every trick and invented a few new ones. When he spoke, his voice came tinged with the warmth of Armenia mellowed by forty years living in Glendale.

"Hello, welcome to Classic Treasure Cars," he greeted with a knowing smile that barely touched his eyes. "I am Tigran, owner of this oasis filled with rare beauties."

Steve took his offered hand. "Nice to meet you, Tigran. Name's Steve."

"So tell me, Steve. What brings you here? Are you searching for something special from when cars were real machines instead of smartphones with wheels?"

Steve laughed. "Exactly! They just don't make 'em like they did thirty years ago. And yeah, I'm actually looking to find a new home for my ride." He nodded over at his Honda. "She's been great and pretty rare too, but I'm ready to let her go, if the price is right."

Tigran cast an uninterested glance at the Prelude. "Prelude? Maybe ninety-eight or ninety-nine. Not exactly rare or valuable, you know? Not sure I'd even be interested. I have standards here."

Steve looked surprised. "It's an Si VTEC!"

Tigran shook his head slightly. "That doesn't add up. There are Si Preludes and there are VTEC Preludes but no Si VTEC, at least not officially in the States. If yours is one, it's probably a fake."

A grin spread across Steve's face. "You clearly know your Preludes, but you're off this time. There was a short run, maybe not officially called Si VTEC, but it was basically a souped-up version of the VTEC model. And listen, I never said it arrived straight from Honda USA, it's a private import."

Tigran nodded thoughtfully. "I get it, but explaining this every time someone claims Tigran peddles junk gets old fast. Still, if you're dead set on selling it, I can offer you ten grand for it."

Steve's smile didn't budge as he replied, "If you're familiar with current prices, these easily fetch up to forty grand nowadays, especially restored ones like mine."

"All my cars are fully restored," Tigran responded coolly.

"So you know what value we're talking about here, a clean title car in top shape? I'll let it go for thirty thousand."

Tigran walked around the Honda, brushing his hand along its flawless paint before pulling out a small gadget from his pocket to scan for any signs of bodywork or repairs. After several minutes with no issues found, he finally made an offer: "Thirteen grand."

Steve raised both hands in disbelief. "That's an insult to Mr Honda himself! And this one's loaded with upgrades, sports intake and custom exhaust among plenty other cool touches! Twenty-eight thousand."

"Probably done by some backyard amateurs who can't tell one end of a wrench from another," Tigran shot back.

“Nope,” Steve countered firmly. “Upgraded by a well-known performance shop up in Seattle.”

“As if Seattle has proper shops!” Tigran snorted. “All the serious ones are here in LA! Still, you seem to know your stuff and love your cars. I’ll stretch it: eighteen grand. Final offer.”

“Twenty-five,” Steve insisted.

“Nope, eighteen it is,” Tigran replied flatly. “And do you have your title on hand?”

Steve pulled out his phone and scrolled through photos before showing Tigran an image of the title document. “Here you go, I can overnight the real thing if you agree on twenty-four grand.”

Tigran threw up his hands as if surrendering to fate: “So you don’t even have it with you right now? Eighteen is my absolute last offer, and that stands for fifteen minutes only; after that it’ll drop to fifteen grand, take it or leave it.”

Steve was about ready to walk away since the deal seemed ridiculous, but then he noticed John giving him a subtle nod towards something else worth checking out. He turned back to Tigran and said, “Hang on, my friend wants me to have a look at another car over there. I’ll be right back.”

Tigran gestured for him to take his time, saying lightly, “Fourteen minutes left on that offer!”

Steve hurried over to John. “What did you spot?” he asked.

John silently pointed at the car ahead.

Steve felt his pulse quicken, it was like bumping into an old friend he hadn’t seen in years but still remembered fondly, a 2001 first-generation Audi TT Quattro Convertible gleaming in silver just

like the one he used to own long ago. The car looked stunning; Steve circled around it before sliding into its pristine leather interior done up in bold red baseball-glove leather with thick stitching everywhere. Inside was spotless, the whole car seemed immaculate inside and out. Steve released the latch and dropped the top; sunlight poured in, making all the aluminium trim sparkle.

He climbed out again and crouched behind the vehicle, inspecting underneath with practiced hands before moving up front to check under the hood at key areas only longtime owners would know mattered most. The price tag taped inside the windscreen read \$19K.

Catching sight of something at the windshield's lower corner brought Steve straight back to Tigran without another word shared with John.

He approached briskly and got straight down to business: "That TT over there, what sort of condition is it in?"

Tigran replied smoothly in his usual unhurried way: "Every car here is kept pristine."

"Timing belt and water pump?" Steve pressed him.

"Both replaced ten thousand miles ago," Tigran answered.

"Ignition system?"

"Even newer than those."

"Any water leak into CCM?"

"Never happened, not once," Tigran assured him.

"How can I be sure all that's true?" Steve pressed further.

The question didn't seem to faze Tigran, it was fair after all, he answered simply: "I've got paperwork for everything: from when

that TT rolled out of Hungary right up till now, all documented service history included.”

Locking eyes with Tigran now, Steve made an offer:

“Straight swap, my Prelude for your TT.”

Tigran added quickly: “Plus difference on top, the TT’s priced at nineteen grand.”

Steve peeled off what cash remained from his pocket and held it out toward him: “Here, whatever this adds up to.”

Seeing Tigran hesitate silently, Steve went on: “Look, I’m only letting my Honda go so cheap because I’m pressed for time right now! You already know this is a sweet deal for you, are we really gonna haggle over a couple hundred bucks?”

Tigran accepted the money quietly, slipped it into his jacket pocket then extended his hand: “Deal, we’ll finish inside! But remember your promise about sending me that title quick, or else my cousins up in Seattle may have words with you, understand?”

Steve grinned easily and shook on it: “Fair enough, I give you my word.”

Chapter 8: The Road Ahead

7:30 PM - Griffith Observatory, Los Angeles, CA

It was nearly half past seven when Steve and John pulled into the Griffith Observatory parking lot. Navigating LA traffic had been its usual test of patience, but sitting behind the wheel with the top down brought Steve a strange mix of irritation and nostalgia. The heat finally won, though, and he closed the roof, letting the air conditioning take over.

If any of this bothered John, he gave no sign.

Steve brought the Audi to a stop and glanced at him. "Well, here we are. Gotta admit, that was quite a ride."

John turned his head slightly. "You are quite an intriguing man, Stipe Kovačević. On one hand, you are riddled with worries and anxieties. On the other hand, you can be daring and even reckless. A moral compass guides your actions, yet your habit of overthinking may lead you toward self-destruction. Fortunately, it seems the usual vices, alcohol, and drugs hold little interest for you, or your journey would have ended long ago. You are remarkably intelligent; you have built an empire from nothing. Yet you often fail to notice the truths right before you. Travelling with you has been delightful."

He reached into his briefcase, removed a thick stack of bills, and placed them on the dashboard. "I am deeply grateful for your assistance. Here is your final payment."

Steve barely looked at the money. He sat there, the pieces of the last few days sliding together in his mind. Every stop along their path: the gas station, the diner, the brothel, even Tigran's lot, had

somehow revolved around John. Every step had been nudged, arranged, or foreseen.

He turned to him sharply. "You knew who I was, didn't you? This whole time. Who are you?"

John smiled, a faint, knowing curve of his lips. "Let us allow that to remain an enigma."

He opened the door to step out, but paused, slipping a hand once more into the briefcase. When it emerged, he held a battered cassette tape, its label marked in Steve's own handwriting: *Rush*.

Steve's breath caught. He had made that mixtape decades ago in Sarajevo, when he was still a teenager and the world felt wide open. For years, it had followed him on every road trip until one day it simply vanished.

"Where did you get that?" he asked quietly.

John's eyes softened. "It was always there, beneath your seat. Tangled in the cables. I found it by chance and thought it best to return it."

Before Steve could answer, John turned and stepped out of the car with that same unhurried grace.

"Who the hell are you?" Steve called after him.

"I'm just a hitchhiker," came the reply, calm and distant. Then the door shut, and John was gone.

Steve scrambled out of the Audi, but the parking lot was empty. The man had vanished as if he had never been there.

He wandered to the railing and looked out toward the Hollywood sign, glowing gold in the last light of day. The sight

pulled him back to the past, to his first visit here with Julia, in an Audi TT they had just bought.

For a long moment, he stood in silence, then took out his phone and began typing quickly. Messages, emails, instructions, closing the loops of a life that no longer fit him. When he was done, he slid back into the driver's seat, lowered the top, and let the warm evening air wash over him.

The TT's interior shimmered in the fading sun. Back home, he had the Porsche for weekdays, the Ferrari for appearances, a garage full of proof that success could be measured in horsepower. But none of them had ever felt like this. Sitting here, in this modest little car that carried so many memories, he felt closer to himself than he had in years.

His phone rang. He answered without hesitation.

"Hey, Kyle. I figured you'd call."

The voice on the other end was fast and nervous. Steve listened calmly, smiling faintly.

"No, I'm not drunk. And no, this isn't a joke. As of ten minutes ago, I'm no longer CEO or Chairman of Flyshiptech International. I've resigned from everything. I'm officially retired. Congratulations! You're acting CEO now, and I'm sure the board will make it permanent soon."

Protests poured through the speaker.

"This isn't up for discussion," Steve said evenly. "I'm done. The meeting with those Idaho folks went great, by the way. They're ready for acquisition. With that deal, Flyshiptech will also own

South America's market. I also promised their CEO a Senior VP post for the region. Make sure he gets it."

More objections.

"Kyle," he said gently, "we built this company together. You're ready to lead it. You're my friend and my partner, and I trust you. But I'm going off the grid for a while. I'll block board calls and press messages. If you need me for something personal, I'll be happy to answer; however, for business matters, I'll be unavailable. Not anymore. I mean it. I'm really done."

The voice on the line went quiet.

"Thank you, Kyle," Steve said softly. "Good luck to you, Mister CEO. Goodbye, my friend."

He ended the call, set the phone face-down on the passenger seat, and looked out over the city, its lights beginning to shimmer in the dusk. Somewhere out there, Julia was living her own life. And here he was, turning the page, ready to start his. Maybe, just maybe, it wasn't too late for their story to become one again.

* * *

8:00 PM - Griffith Observatory, Los Angeles, CA

Steve sat in silence for several minutes, summoning the courage for what he was about to do.

At last, he picked up his phone and dialed the number etched permanently in his memory. The line rang again and again with no answer. His heart began to sink.

Then, finally, a quiet, cautious voice came on. "Hello?"

Steve drew a deep breath, trying to steady himself. It felt like that moment years ago when he'd asked out a girl for the first time, knowing rejection was likely.

"Julia, it's me," he began softly. "Please, just listen for a minute. I've got a few things I need to say." His voice trembled, but his words carried warmth and sincerity. "First off, I told my lawyers to agree to everything you asked for. I'm done fighting. If you still want the divorce, I'll respect your decision."

Before she could speak, he continued. "I've also resigned from every position I held. Officially retired now. I finally realized life's too short to spend chasing another billion dollars. That chapter's closed for good. And one more thing," he added, smiling faintly, "you won't believe where I am right now. I'm at the Griffith Observatory, sitting in the Audi TT! Our TT! The one we bought after our first big success. The same car we drove all over the country together. It still has that little scratch you made on the dash when you crawled over from the driver's seat in the heat of the moment."

He paused, the memory tightening his throat. "So yeah, fate brought me back to it. And now it's ours again, or it could be. My plan is simple: a long road trip with no destination, just backroads and small towns. And I... I want to ask if you'd like to come with me."

He waited, but there was only silence. The longer it stretched, the heavier it felt. So he went on, voice raw with honesty. "I've spent a lot of time thinking about how things went wrong between us. I

was selfish. I'm sorry for that. If you decide to join me, I promise we'll start fresh. I won't drag the past into it. I just want a future with you again. Like before, when we were happy."

Still no answer. Steve's hope began to fade. "If you don't want to give it another shot, I understand," he added quietly. "But the invitation stands either way. I just want you to know I miss you."

The silence broke at last. "I would really love that, Steve," Julia said softly.

He almost didn't trust his ears. "So... that's a yes? You'll come?"

"Yes, Steve. I will." Her voice grew steadier. "But please, let me say something too. I've thought a lot about us. I was angry for a long time. I even hated you for a while. Losing what we had destroyed me. And for a time, I wanted you to hurt like I did. But now... without you, I feel lost too."

She paused, then added with quiet conviction, "If you're ready to devote yourself to me again, I'm ready to do the same. I want nothing more than to be with you."

Steve's voice softened, almost trembling. "I love you, Julia."

"And I've always loved you, Steve," she whispered. "But there's something I need you to ask... the same question you asked me the day we separated. The one that's haunted you ever since. Please, Steve. Ask it."

He hesitated, wanting to tell her it didn't matter anymore. But she needed to hear it, so he obeyed. "Julia... did you sleep with Jack?"

"No, Steve," she replied gently but firmly. "Nothing ever happened. Not with him, not with anyone, since the day we made our promise to each other."

Relief flooded through him, breaking into a shaky laugh. "Thank you, Julia. So... how long do you need to pack?" His tone brightened. "And don't forget, the trunk's tiny."

Julia laughed softly. "Half an hour."

"Perfect! A limo will be there by then. It'll take you straight to Paine Field, and from there our jet will bring you to Vegas. We can spend a few days there, or just hit the road right away. It's all up to us."

"See you in Vegas, Loverboy."

"See you in Vegas, Happy Legs," Steve answered, grinning.

He ended the call, sent a short message with the details, and started the engine.

Before pulling away, he glanced in the rearview mirror, and for a brief, unreal moment, he thought he saw John standing on the sidewalk, smiling faintly and waving goodbye. Then the image was gone.

Steve reached for the cassette labeled *Rush* and slid it into the player. The tape hissed softly before giving way to the familiar voice of Geddy Lee:

Start a new chapter, I find what I'm after / Is changing every day...

The change of a season is enough of a reason to want to get away.

Tapping the steering wheel, Steve sang along under his breath, smiling as the city lights shimmered ahead. Then he pressed the

accelerator and drove toward a new beginning with Julia, their own version of happily ever after.